



GOVERNMENT OF INDIA



BRICS
INDIA 2026

BUILDING FOR RESILIENCE, INNOVATION,
COOPERATION AND SUSTAINABILITY

BRICS SUMMIT

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 New Delhi, India

Emerging Economies
Emerging Possibilities



CSC 14129/13/0015/2627

PUREPOLITICS

Nepal Death Toll Rises to 1,295 with 275 Indians Still Missing



The death toll from devastating Nepal flash floods rose to 1,295 on Friday even as **two men were rescued from a tunnel after being trapped for nine days**. Meanwhile, 275 Indians remained missing while 166 others were rescued, the Ministry of External Affairs said on Friday. >> 2

Maldives Awards Thilafushi Port Contract to China Co >> 2

HarperCollins India to Publish Sonia's Memoir on Nov 10



HarperCollins India on Friday announced it will publish Congress leader Sonia Gandhi's memoir, 'Belonging: A Journey of Love', in India on November 10. This comes after Penguin Random House India decided not to publish the book over reported differences with the author about certain contents. >> 3

DUTY-FREE MARKET ACCESS

New FTAs Open Up Big Window for Exports



Eight new FTAs signed in the last five years have opened duty-free market access of \$982 billion in electronics, \$631 billion in agriculture, and \$442 billion in gems & jewellery for Indian exporters. **Kirtika Suneja** reports. >> 5

COS SEEN SPENDING ABOVE CSR MANDATE

Goyal Asks Cos to Scale Social-Impact Projects



Real inclusion is the only way to achieve Viksit Bharat goal by 2047, commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said Friday, calling on India Inc to scale up social-impact programmes to ensure all people can be covered. >> 4

AFTER TAX BREATH

FPIs Keen to Move G-sec Funds Next Day



Foreign portfolio investors are nudging Sebi and banks to provide them the flexibility to remit funds a day after government securities are sold as they are exempt from taxes on bonds with effect from April 1, 2026. **Sugata Ghosh** reports. >> 9

OpenAI's GPT-6 Astra Raises Bar for AI Models



OpenAI's latest GPT-6 Astra appears to have raised the bar in the frontier AI model race with its ability to perform complex, multi-step knowledge work on its own across financial modelling, chip design, geospatial mapping, 3D modelling and software engineering. **Himanshi Lohchab** reports. >> 8

Beer Gets its Buzz Going as Spirits Market Sobers Up

State-level tax increases hurt demand for spirits, with growth at only 2%; beer volumes jump 17%, led by Maharashtra and Karnataka

Aanya Thakur & Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: India's spirits market is losing its kick as higher prices and state tax changes push consumers toward beer, which is gaining momentum across some of the country's biggest markets for alcoholic drinks. Volumes of spirits, which exclude fermented alcoholic beverages, climbed 2% in the June quarter, while beer volumes surged 17%, according to officials citing excise data. Whisky, which makes up nearly two-thirds of the spirits market, declined 1% as demand for mass-priced brands weakened. Brandy and vodka sales expanded, but were not enough to offset the decline in whisky. "The growth has been low largely because overall demand has remained subdued. Maharashtra's IMFL market also did not grow, while the lower-priced segment in Karnataka was impacted by price disparity and did not see growth," said Amar Sinha, managing director, Allied Blenders. "Seasonal factors, particularly Shravan in the North, also weighed on consumption in August, further moderating demand. We expect the market to start picking up from September as these temporary factors ease." The slowdown comes as state-level tax changes have made spirits more expensive compared to beer. Maharashtra, Karnataka, Odisha and West Bengal have raised taxes on Indian-made foreign liquor, or IMFL, while keeping beer prices unchanged or, in some cases, reducing them. This has helped beer gain ground, particularly in Maharashtra and Karnataka, among the top liquor consuming markets. The category has also benefited from the summer season and below-normal monsoon rains.

Brewing Shift

VOLUME GROWTH IN Q1 (YOY, %)

Overall Spirits: 2

-0.7

Whisky

6

Brandy

-0.7

Rum

39

Vodka

-37

Gin

17

Beer

Source: Industry officials quoting excise data

CHARITY COMMISSIONER ORDER PUTS TATA SONS' STAKE IN FOCUS

Billion-\$ Question Mark Emerges over RNT Estate

Ruling allows NRTT to act if former Tata Sons chairman transferred shares violating terms agreed by his father

Back in Spotlight

833 Tata Sons shares NRTT transferred to Naval Tata in 1989

CONDITIONAL TRANSFER

Shares will remain within family lineage

Or returned to the trust

RATAN TATA'S WILL

Shares bequeathed equally to two personal charitable institutions

This is being seen as breach of undertaking by Naval Tata

Maha charity commissioner's Sept 2 ruling has brought condition attached to share transfer in focus

₹10,000 cr+

Estimated value of Tata Sons' 0.83% stake in question

WHAT NEXT?

NRTT will have to engage with Will executors to discuss matter and enforce the terms

Ratan Tata Trust (NRTT). The order puts in focus shares amounting to 0.83% equity stake in Tata Sons that Ratan Tata had bequeathed equally to two charities structured to remain independent of Tata Trusts — Ratan Tata Endowment Trust and Ratan Tata Endowment Fund.

Tata Chem Counters Kenya's Exit Order



Tata Chemicals has said its Kenyan unit is "fully compliant with regulatory requirements" and has submitted all documents sought by authorities. >> 4

Curbs with Benefits >> 10

DOLLAR INFLOWS USHER IN RECORD FUNDS

Forex Stockpile Climbs to New Heights, Pulls Re Out of Slump

Reserves surge to over \$740b in August-end; Indian unit at 94.49/\$

Our Bureau

Kolkata: India's foreign-exchange reserves scaled a new summit of \$740.8 billion at the end of August 28, climbing for the ninth straight week, as dedicated dollar-inflow programmes garnered record funds overseas. The forex stockpile surge, seen as a proxy of enduring global confidence in India's world-leading growth credentials, has also helped the local currency rebound after a rather lacklustre FY26. The rupee, in lockstep with smart gains in forex reserves, advanced more than 2.5% from its lows late May, closing at 94.49 to the dollar Friday—the highest in nearly two months. The forex kitty swelled \$11.48 billion in the week to August 28, the latest weekly data published Friday by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) showed. The RBI has used a part of its forex arsenal to defend the rupee and prevent imported inflation, after the local unit touched a lifetime low of 96.96 to a dollar on May 20.

Fatter Kitty

FOREX RESERVES (\$, B)

Foreign currency assets	600.7
Gold	116.4
SDRs	18.8
Reserve position in IMF	4.9
Total	740.8

Source: RBI

\$73.9b added in past nine weeks

\$729.3b previous high seen on Aug 21

Rupee has gained 1.4% since June 4 following dollar mobilisation drive

PROVIDING RELEVANT RECORDS TO AAIB: AIR INDIA

Phuket-Delhi Flight: Probe Finds Hydraulic Failure; Pilot Sacked

Simultaneous loss of all 3 hydraulic systems 'unusual', raises more questions, say experts

Forum Gandhi

Mumbai: A preliminary investigation by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) found that an Air India Airbus A320 briefly lost pressure in all three hydraulic systems at 36,000 feet during an August 4 flight. The incident caused the aircraft to gain and then lose altitude, triggering an autopilot disconnect and a stall warning and injuring 24 people. The pilot-in-command on the Phuket-Delhi flight, later found positive for a psychoactive substance, was sacked by the carrier, Air India said Friday. The AAIB did not have any direction for Airbus or engine maker CFM International. Experts said the simultaneous loss of all three hydraulic systems was uncommon and raised questions about a possible common cause. Air India flight AI2379, an Airbus A320-251N, was carrying 145 people. "The confirmation of use of psycho-active substance is a serious concern," the bureau said, recommending that the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) take "appropriate actions" on priority to prevent the abuse of psychoactive substances. Air India said Friday it had terminated the pilot's employment with immediate effect and was cooperating with investigators by providing access to relevant "operational, maintenance and technical records."

AI2379 Factsheet

HYDRAULICS

All 3 systems showed loss of pressure within 4 seconds

ALTITUDE

Climbed 372 ft, then fell 292 ft

INJURED

24 people; 4 seriously injured

PILOT

PIC non-negative for psychoactive substance in both tests

No AAIB recommendations for Airbus or CFM

Source: AAIB report

OFS OF 148.9M SHARES

Sebi Gives Green Light to NSE for ₹31.5kcr IPO

Nod comes day after SC accepted bourse's settlement in co-lo cases

Our Bureau

Mumbai: India's capital markets regulator Friday cleared the long-awaited initial public offering of the National Stock Exchange (NSE), paving the path for the country's second-largest initial share sale that will likely raise up to ₹31,500 crore. The nod comes a day after the Supreme Court accepted settlement terms between the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) and NSE in the co-location and dark fibre cases, which have often been cited as reasons for the delay in initial share sales first proposed nearly a decade ago by the bourse that generates the world's largest equity trading volumes. By size, the NSE share sale would trail the proposed ₹37,000-crore IPO of Jio Platforms, which may debut in October or November, ET reported Friday. Sebi said in a communication Friday it had issued its final "observations" to the NSE. Receipt of Sebi's observations allows companies to move ahead with their IPO process. NSE's issue will entirely be an offer for sale of 148.9 million shares.

NSE shares will be listed on the platform of its older rival, the BSE

Long Delay >> 10

Rentomojo IPO Likely at ₹4.2kcr Valuation



Rentomojo is expected to go public at a valuation of ₹4,246 crore, based on the upper end of its ₹384-404 per share price band announced Friday. **Disha Acharya & Tanishka Dubey** report. >> 10

WIDENING DATA POOL

AIS to Include GST Returns, Off-market Foreign Investments



The I-T department is broadening the scope of annual information statements (AIS), bringing in GST returns, foreign MF investments outside banking routes, and off-market securities. **Anuradha Shukla** reports. >> 5

EMISSIONS TRADING MODEL

Rio Takes a Leaf Out of Gujarat's 'Green' Playbook



Gujarat's emissions trading model, recognised by Earthshot prize, has found a taker abroad. Rio de Janeiro has decided to take a leaf out of state's book and set up a market for pollutants. **Urmi Goswami** reports. >> 8

ROLE REJIG FROM DECEMBER 1

Chakravarty to Log into Adobe as Next Prez & CEO

After 18 yrs at helm, Narayen will become executive chairperson

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Adobe has named Indian-origin Anil Chakravarty as its next president and CEO. He will succeed long-time chief Shantanu Narayen, who led the software giant for 18 years. Set to take charge from December 1, Chakravarty joins the ranks of prominent Indian executives at the helm of global technology majors including Microsoft's Satya Nadella, Google parent Alphabet's Sundar Pichai, Arvind Krishna of IBM, Nikesh Arora of Palo Alto Networks, and YouTube's Neal Mohan. Chakravarty had been president of Adobe's customer experience orchestration business and worldwide field operations, having joined the company in January 2020 from global enterprise cloud data management firm Informatica. Meanwhile, Narayen will transition to executive chairperson in December, the company said in a statement. Earlier this year, Adobe had announced plans for Narayen to step down once a successor was named. He has focused on leveraging AI to drive the \$113 billion company's comprehensive enterprise software offerings, by leading development on interconnected, agentic AI platforms such as Adobe CX Enterprise, GenStudio and Brand Visibility, Adobe said. He has been instrumental in scaling Adobe Experience Platform and the introduction of new product innovations like CX Enterprise Coworker, the company said. He also led the acquisition and integration of enterprise software platforms Workfront and Semrush.

Top Job

Chakravarty serving as president of Adobe's customer experience orchestration biz & worldwide field ops

Joined co in Jan 2020 after leading global enterprise cloud data mgmt firm Informatica for 4 yrs

Former tech exec at Symantec, VeriSign and McKinsey & Company

Education

BTech in Computer Science & Engg, IIT, Varanasi

Masters of Science & PhD from MIT



SATELLITE TO GATHER STRATEGIC DATA

Isro Launches GSLV-F17



Isro on Friday successfully launched 2,367 kg EOS-05 Earth-observation satellite aboard the GSLV-F17 launch vehicle from Sriharikota. >> 10

AFTER PROBE INTO ALLEGED FRAUD...

PVR INOX Exec Was Shown the Door in April

Film exhibitor scans 'kickbacks'; co-promoters may be under fire

Shally Seth Mohile

Mumbai: PVR INOX, India's biggest film exhibitor, asked a senior executive to leave in April following an internal investigation into alleged kickbacks from developers involved in building cinema properties, people familiar with the matter told ET. The alleged kickbacks were made over several years and could aggregate up to ₹200 crore, said one of the people cited above. The allegations involve a senior executive who was close to the company's promoters, raising questions about how long the alleged payments continued and whether others were aware of the malpractices, the people said. The circumstances could also bring scrutiny on PVR INOX co-promoters Ajay and Sanjeev Bijli, who have been running the company since the merger of PVR and INOX became effective in February 2023, said the people cited above. The executive in question, Pramod Arora, was the chief executive officer for growth and investment at PVR INOX, the people said. The investigation also sought to establish the extent of the alleged wrongdoing and determine whether others were involved, said the sources. The matter has also been discussed by the company's board in recent meetings, they said. "This was going on for several years," said a person with direct knowledge of the matter.

Behind the Scene

₹200 crore Alleged kickbacks over several years



April 2026: Senior executive Pramod Arora asked to leave after internal probe

Board scrutiny: Probe also examining whether others were involved

Allegations could raise questions for co-promoters Ajay & Sanjeev Bijli

Footprint 1,786 screens across 356 properties, 113 cities

Beyond Metros >> 3

'Bull Run on Beer' >> 10

ABOUT 5,000 MISSING; 13,093 RESCUED; OVER 32,000 PEOPLE AFFECTED

Nepal Death Toll Rises to 1,295; Two Workers Rescued Alive from Tunnel

Agencies

Kathmandu: The death toll due to flash floods in Nepal rose to 1,295 on Friday as more bodies were recovered from the affected areas while two men were rescued alive from a tunnel at the Trishuli 3A hydropower project after being trapped for nine days.

The joint command of security forces is actively conducting search and rescue operations for the estimated 5,000 missing. So far, 13,093 people have been rescued from the affected areas. The devastating flash floods in Nepal have affected more than 32,000 people and damaged roads, bridges, schools and healthcare facilities, according to a preliminary government report released on Friday.

The two men rescued alive from the tunnel were identified as Kabir Maharjan, 45, a mechanical supervisor on the project, and Sanjay Sah, 30, a foreman, according to the Public Relations Directorate of the Nepal Army. Maharjan was flown to Nepal Army Hospital in Chhauni, Kathmandu, and his condition is said to be critical, while Sah is under treatment at the Trishuli hospital in Nuwakot, according to Raja Ram Basnet, Nepali Army spokesperson.

Sah, who is from Saptari district in Madhesh province, told security personnel that he was chanting 'Hare Krishna' mantra for the last nine days while trapped inside the tunnel.

Meanwhile, the sixth and seventh relief flights from India carrying 21.5 tonnes of relief materials arrived in Kathmandu on Thursday night. "India's support to Nepal's relief efforts for Rasuwa flash flood continues: 6th and 7th relief flights (C-130Js) arrived in Kathmandu today carrying 21.5 tonnes of relief assistance, including forensic



AFTER 9 DAYS

Two men rescued alive from the tunnel identified as Kabir Maharjan, 45, a mechanical supervisor, and Sanjay Sah, 30, a foreman

'1,907 HAVE SAFELY CROSSED OVER TO NEPAL FROM CHINA'

'275 Indian Nationals Remain Missing'

NEW DELHI: Two hundred seventy-five Indians remained missing while 166 others were rescued following the devastating flash floods along the Nepal-Tibet border, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Friday. It said that 1,907 Indian nationals have safely crossed over to Nepal from China. MEA spokesman Randhir Jaiswal said India supplied around 95 tonnes of relief material to Nepal. "275 Indian nationals remain missing. We continue to be in close touch with the Nepali government," Jaiswal said at his regular media briefing. "We deeply appreciate the efforts of the Nepalese authorities in this regard. So far, 166 Indian nationals have been rescued and 1,907 Indian nationals have safely crossed into Nepal from China," he said. —PTI

Developed countries who historically are responsible for the emissions & have contributed overwhelmingly to this crisis, must take lead in reducing emissions and supporting developing countries by way of finance and technology transfer to meet this challenge

RANDHIR JAISWAL
MEA Spokesperson

kits and medical supplies," India's ambassador to Nepal Naveen Srivastava said in a post on X. "These materials were handed over to Nepal, and will help strengthen ongoing Nepali relief and rescue efforts and support communities affected by Rasuwa floods," he added.

Around 600 children remain unaccounted for in Nepal's Rasuwa and Nuwakot districts. The disaster has also taken a toll on teachers and school staff. Education units confirmed that 22 teachers and school staff members remain missing across both districts.

Australian disaster response specialists left for Nepal on Friday to join the search for survivors, as the Australian government expressed "serious concerns" for the welfare of its 36 missing citizens.

The UN and humanitarian partners have launched a \$49.6 million flash appeal to deliver life-saving relief to over 84,000 people affected by the floods.



Victim's daughter Nishu Azad at Delhi Police station — ANI

Influencer Who Bragged About Cracking Man's Skull Detained After CJP Protest

Press Trust Of India

New Delhi: Delhi Police detained Hindutva influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj in UP on Friday, hours after the Cockroach Janta Party staged a protest outside the Parliament Street police station demanding his arrest for assaulting a student's father, a crime he bragged about in an interview.

The detention came after CJP representatives, accompanied by Azad Samaj Party (Kanshi Ram) chief and Nagina MP Chandrashekhar Azad and MP Pappu Yadav, met police officials and were assured that action would be taken against Bhardwaj within 72 hours.

The delegation sought the addition of attempt-to-murder, criminal intimidation and SC/ST Act provisions to the case and demanded a separate FIR over alleged rape threats, abuse and objectionable images targeting the assault victim Sanjay Kumar's daughter Nishu.

Bhardwaj, who describes himself as a "kattar" (staunch) Hindu, claimed in an interview that he cracked the skull of Nishu's father and got away with it because of his political connections.

Bhardwaj said in the interview, "I cracked the skull of Nishu's father... But I was not even jailed. The world should know this. I was out and about through the night," Bhardwaj said in the interview.

Police sources said Bhardwaj fled from Naithla village on a Royal Enfield motorcycle towards Khurja before a police team reached there to apprehend him. He was wearing a helmet to conceal his identity, they said.

Police said Kumar was medically examined at RML Hospital and his injuries were opined to be simple in nature.



Terrorist Killed in J&K Encounter; Op Continues

'ANOTHER INFILTRATOR HOLED UP IN THE AREA'

Identity of slain militant yet to be established

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: A militant was killed in the forest area of Budgam in central Kashmir during an operation on Friday, the armed forces said.

Based on specific intelligence inputs, a joint search operation was launched by the Army, J&K Police and CRPF in the Ashdar Gali, also known as Ashtar Gali, area in the upper reaches of Budgam, officials said.

"Vigilant troops observed suspicious activity and upon being challenged, terrorists opened fire, prompting a fierce exchange of gunfire during which one terrorist neutralised and one AK rifle and other war-like stores recovered. Search operation is in progress," Indian Army's Srinagar-based Chinara Corps said in a statement.

The identity of the slain militant is yet to be established and will be confirmed after forensic examination, officials said. Security forces are searching for another suspected infiltrator believed to be holed up in the area. "We have been following this lead for several days now and this particular operation started on Thursday when the contact was established with the terrorists and 10 Para in Ashtar, Dudhpathri area of Khansahib in Budgam," said an official. Ashdar Gali lies between Poonch district in Jammu, across the Pir Panjal range, and Budgam district in Kashmir. Police had also set up a temporary operating base at Dishkal, between Dudhpathri and Ashdar Gali.

The area is a popular trekking route that was closed after the Pahalgam attack in April 2025, along with several other destinations. Most of these destinations were reopened this year, but the trekking route remains closed.

Meanwhile, Kashmir Inspector General of Police Sujit Kumar chaired a security review meeting for the upcoming International Film Festival, which begins in Srinagar on Monday. The meeting focused on strengthening security arrangements and ensuring preparedness for the smooth and secure conduct of the festival.

IN POONCH DISTRICT

Army Rescues Girl Found Floating in Mendhar Nala

MENDHAR | JAMMU: Army personnel rescued an unidentified teenage girl after she was found floating in Mendhar Nala near Balmoi in Poonch district on Friday, officials said. The girl, aged around 14-16 years, was noticed in the flowing water at around 1:30 pm, following which Army personnel launched an immediate rescue operation and pulled her to safety, they said. She was found unconscious and was initially provided medical assistance before being shifted to Mendhar sub-district hospital for further treatment. —PTI

Maldives Awards Contract for Phase 1 of Thilafushi Port to A Chinese Company

Dipanj Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: The Maldives has renewed its commitment to jointly develop the Thilafushi Port with India, signing a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with a Chinese company for development of the first phase of the project. The development has triggered alarm bells in the strategic community as it can boost China's presence in India's southern neighbourhood.

Maldives Ports Limited recently signed an MoU with China Harbour Engineering Company (CHEC), awarding the port project on a single nomination basis even as CHEC has a patchy track record. Besides Sri Lanka's Hambantota Port, CHEC has been involved in ports in South

MALDIVES GOES BACK ON ITS COMMITMENT

In 2024, during the Maldives President Mohamed Muizzu's India visit, the two sides had announced plans to jointly develop the Thilafushi Port to decongest the Male Port

America, Kenya and the Pacific, and has been infamous for financial and project mismanagement, according to people familiar with the matter.

CHEC and its parent company, CCC, have been involved in the Guyana Airport Project, the Nivasha Inland Container Depot in Kenya and the Nauru Port Redevelopment project, among others.

A strategic affairs expert said on condition of anonymity that CHEC has a record of delivering projects that have created governance, fiscal, environmental, political and strategic risks.

The decision to engage CHEC at a time when the Maldivian economy is in a precarious position, accentuated by the West Asian conflict, has also raised eyebrows. The Maldives' current account deficit and fiscal deficit

are projected to increase substantially this year while gross domestic product growth is expected to dip below 1% compared to 6% last year.

In 2024, during the Maldives President Mohamed Muizzu's India visit, the two sides had announced plans to jointly develop the Thilafushi Port to decongest the Male Port.

The island nation's decision to renege on its commitment to India comes shortly after Muizzu lauded India's role in the Greater Male Connectivity Project (GMCP), which links Male with the industrial hub of Thilafushi. GMCP is the largest infrastructure project undertaken in the Maldives.

India has undertaken several infrastructure projects in the Maldives over the past eight years, benefiting several thousand Maldivians.

Poliloquy R PRASAD

Masked men vandalise TMC office in Kol.

Cowardly act! We never wore masks in our day!

Karnataka CM to Lead All-Party Team to PM for Farm Loan Waiver

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar on Friday said he would lead an all-party delegation to Prime Minister Narendra Modi to seek a waiver of farm loans in Karnataka amid drought conditions in more than 100 taluks.

He said the Centre should share the burden of providing relief to farmers, arguing that Modi himself had acknowledged the drought situation. He urged BJP state president BY Vijayendra, the leader of the Opposition in the state assembly R Ashoka and other Opposition leaders to join the delegation and press the Centre for a loan waiver.

The state government has also stepped up drought relief measures, including cloud-seeding operations aimed at augmenting rainfall. Water resources minister N Cheluvarayanaswamy flagged off a plane from HAL airport in Bengaluru on Friday to carry out cloud seeding by releasing rain-inducing chemicals into clouds. The state government has allocated ₹28.52 crore for the project.

PREPARATORY MEETING Four countries push for concrete initiatives on security, technology, emergency response

Quad Sherpas Meet Ahead of Mins' Talk in Oct

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Foreign secretary Vikram Misri hosted a meeting of Quad Sherpas in New Delhi to prepare for the grouping's foreign ministers' meeting in Australia in October, the ministry of external affairs said on Thursday.

The discussions covered key areas of Quad cooperation, including maritime and transnational security, economic prosperity and security, critical and emerging technologies, and humanitarian assistance and emergency response, the ministry said.

The four Sherpas also exchanged views on developments in the Indo-Pacific and the broader regional and global context.

The Sherpas reaffirmed the importance of focusing on concrete, action-oriented initiatives. The meeting was convened to take forward the outcomes of the Quad foreign ministers' meeting held in New Delhi on May 26.

Australia's deputy secretary,



Strategic Planning and Coordination Group, Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, Elly Lawson; Japan's senior deputy minister for foreign affairs Hiroyuki Namazu; and US ambassador to India Sergio Gorrer attended the meeting.

At their last meeting in Manila on the sidelines of an Asean meeting, the Quad foreign ministers backed the practical implementation of the Asean Outlook on the Indo-Pacific (AOIP), seeking greater regional support for the grouping's efforts to ensure a stable Indo-Pacific.

At the May meeting in New Delhi, the Quad foreign ministers also announced plans to convene an Indo-Pacific Energy Security initiative involving strategic crude oil reserves and emergency response measures, as countries including some Quad members face energy supply-chain disruptions due to the war in West Asia.

ON BECOMING ITALY'S LONGEST CONTINUOUSLY SERVING PM

Modi Congratulates Meloni, She Thanks him

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi congratulated his Italian counterpart Giorgia Meloni on Friday as she became Italy's longest continuously serving postwar PM, calling the historic feat a clear sign of the Italian people's trust and confidence in her leadership. Thanking Modi, Meloni said the relationship between Italy and India is stronger than ever today and together the two countries continue to strengthen the bond between Europe and Asia as well, working side by side to also develop the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor. Meloni, 49, has been Italy's prime minister since October 22, 2022. On Thursday, after 1,413 days in office, she became the country's longest-serving uninterrupted prime minister since World War II. She is also the first woman to hold the position. —PTI



Heavy Rainfall Disrupts Normal Life, Delhi-NCR Hit by Waterlogging

NEW DELHI: Parts of northern India witnessed heavy rainfall on Friday, with the India Meteorological Department forecasting light to moderate showers over the next few days. In the NCR region, several roads in Delhi and Gurugram were inundated, leading to traffic snarls at prominent places. In the national capital, heavy waterlogging near the Indira Gandhi International Airport disrupted flight operations. —PTI



Mirwaiz Again Prevented From Addressing Jama Masjid on Friday

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: Mirwaiz Umar Farooq was once again prevented from addressing the Friday congregation at the Jama Masjid in Srinagar, a decision he described as punishment for voicing people's concerns.

The Hurriyat leader, who is also the head cleric of Kashmir and leads the Muttahida Majlis-e-Ulema, a grouping of about 50 religious organisations across Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, also said that separatist leader and former militant Yasin Malik's submission before the court deciding not to contest the case while maintaining his innocence called for serious reflection on commitments made to him.

"The policy to silence the pulpit of Jama Masjid and punish me from voicing people's concerns and standing up in defence of their rights and for justice continues unabated. I am again put under house arrest today on a Friday, when I was also to preside over a function in connection with the blessed Islamic month of Rabi ul Awwal at Jama Masjid in Srinagar," said the Mirwaiz.

DOUBLE-ENGINE GOVT CONSTANTLY MAKING EFFORTS FOR THIS: UTTAR PRADESH CM

Mathura, Vrindavan to Get Grand Complexes Like Ayodhya: Yogi

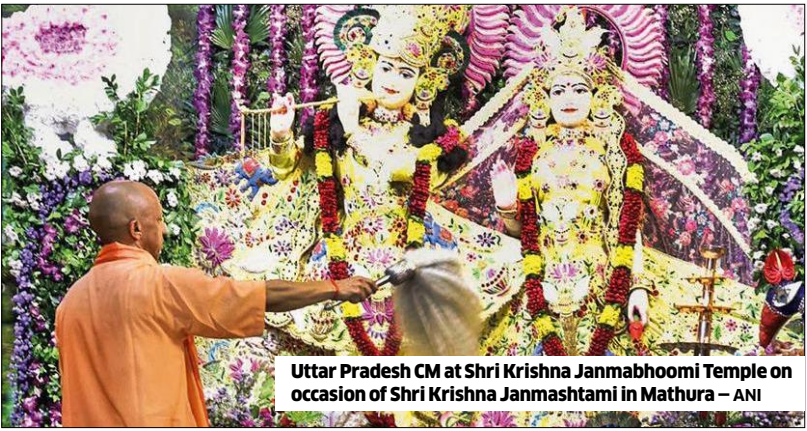
‘Previous govts were afraid to visit Krishna Janmabhoomi as they were worried about vote bank’

Sanjay Singh

New Delhi: Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath on Friday said his government plans to develop big temple complexes in Mathura and Vrindavan on the lines of Kashi and Ayodhya with the support of the Centre. “Our effort is that grand complexes be prepared in Mathura-Vrindavan, just like those of Shri Ayodhya Dham and Kashi,” Adityanath told a gathering of devotees in Mathura on the Janmashtami festival.

He alleged that the previous governments were afraid of visiting Shri Krishna Janmabhoomi because they were worried about their vote bank. “This government has faith in Krishna Kanhaiya, Prabhu Shri Ram, Baba Vishwanath and Maa Vindhyavasini. But those whose faith lies in Babar and Aurangzeb; can they respect your faith?” the CM said. He first offered his prayers in the temple and then addressed the devotees.

Highlighting the construction of “the world’s largest temple” in Ayodhya, Adityanath said the residents of Ayodhya could not imagine that such grand development would ever take place there. “There were neither roads nor electricity, and there was no adequate water supply. Heaps of garbage were found everywhere. Ayodhya was connected to the railway network by a single line. Devotees who went there would return in tears after witnessing the disorder and chaos,” Adityanath said. “Today, around one lakh devotees visit Ayodhya Dham



‘DEFAMING AYODHYA’

Today, the world’s grandest temple of Shri Ram is in Ayodhya. Those who don’t like this are defaming Ayodhya: Yogi

every day and the figure increases” anywhere between five lakhs to 50 lakhs on special occasions such as Ram Navami, the month of Kartik, Sawan Jhula Mela and Deepotsav. He said there is no inconvenience anywhere and an extraordinary example

of social equality is also evident. An international airport has been built in Ayodhya in the name of Maharishi Valmiki, four-lane roads have been constructed from all directions, and the railway line has been doubled, the CM said.

He said the Sanatan faith continued to grow despite a foreign invader’s attempt to destroy the faith 500 years ago, in 1528. “Those invaders who considered themselves unconquered have no trace left today. They have all disappeared. But our faith was never defeated,” Adityanath said. “Today the world’s grandest and largest temple of Prabhu Shri Ram has been built in Ayodhya. Those who do not like all this are defaming Ayodhya.”

FIRST VISIT AFTER BEING APPOINTED IN-CHARGE OF POLL-BOUND UTTAR PRADESH

Tawde Sets Low-Key Tone for UP Visit

Kumar Anshuman

New Delhi: BJP general secretary Vinod Tawde is set to visit Uttar Pradesh on Saturday, marking his first trip to the state since being appointed the party’s in-charge of UP.

For his two-day visit, Tawde has instructed party leaders and workers to avoid an ostentatious welcome, posters and road shows. He has sent out a message that the focus should be on work ahead of assembly elections. The instruction has become a point of discussion as a few days ago, another BJP general secretary, Harish Dwivedi, was accorded a grand welcome by the state leaders on his arrival in Lucknow. The former Lok Sabha MP from UP was visiting Lucknow for the first time after being appointed as party general secretary.

Similarly, on August 4, Rohit Mishra, the newly appointed BJP UP Yuva Morcha president, was given a grand welcome



FOCUS ON POLLS

The newly-appointed in-charge for UP has instructed BJP leaders to focus on work ahead of elections

me in Kanpur, which caused traffic jams across the city.

Meanwhile, the Uttar Pradesh unit of the BJP has announced its regional team of office bearers. Tawde is expected to meet all district in-charges at the party office in Lucknow to review the preparatory work. **He will also be meeting chief minister Yogi Adityanath and the deputy chief ministers, Keshav Prasad Maurya and Brajesh Pathak.** Sources told ET that the initial discussion would be on organising a month-long celebration to mark Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s 25 years in executive office, spanning the time from his first oath as the chief minister of Gujarat to his current tenure as prime minister. Tawde was in-charge of Bihar during the state Assembly elections and he has been trusted with UP after his successful Bihar stint.

BJP general secretary (organisation) BL Santhosh will be visiting the state on September 7 to meet the party workers.

FADNAVIS CONDEMNS ATTACK ON PUNE RESIDENT SEEKING DJ BAN

DJ Ban During Festivals Puts BJP, VHP on Opposite Sides in Maha

Krishna Kumar

Mumbai: A controversy over bans on loud DJs during festivals like Janmashtami and the upcoming Ganesh Utsav has divided the ruling BJP and VHP, sparked violence against those seeking a ban, and drawn interventions from Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis and NCP(SP) chief Sharad Pawar.

This comes even as local party leaders openly vow to defy the restrictions imposed by the administration. Pune resident Vidyannand Bapat has been clamouring for a ban on DJs during Ganesh Utsav and other festivals in Pune, claiming that the high-decibel levels are inconveniencing locals.

On Thursday, Bapat was assaulted in public by an irate member of a Ganesh Utsav mandal, an incident that drew condemnation from across the political spectrum. Pawar said, “Festivals should bring joy. What Bapat is saying about noise pollution has some substance to it. In a democracy, beating up someone for his views is wrong.”

Fadnavis has vowed strong action against Bapat’s attacker. “Everyone has the right to express their opinion. Attacking someone for expressing their views is not right,” said the CM.

While the rest of Maharashtra debates the ban, several cities have cracked down on the use of DJs. Nagpur Police Commissioner Vishwas Nangre Patil has announced a ban on DJs during the Janmashtami celebrations, with Nagpur BJP president Dayashankar Tiwari vowing to violate the ban.

VHP, which until last year had been vociferously demanding a ban on DJs during Hindu festivals, has now taken an about-turn, with local VHP leader Amol Thakre questioning why only Hindu festivals are being targeted.

Meanwhile, Solapur Police Commissioner M Rajkumar has also banned DJs, Dolby systems and powerful laser lights. Similar bans have also been imposed in Bhandara and Sangli.

TWO IRRIGATION MILESTONES CAPTURE TRANSFORMATION OF ANDHRA PRADESH’S LONGEST-SERVING POLITICAL LEADER

CEO CM to Water Man: Naidu’s Long Journey Enters a New Phase

Message from Amaravati is clear: In this innings, TDP chief wants his legacy to flow through water

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: When N Chandrababu Naidu released water through the Polavaram Left Main Canal on Wednesday, it marked more than the commissioning of another irrigation link. Just days earlier, he had inaugurated the first phase of the Poola Subbaiah Veligonda Project — a project whose foundation stone he had laid more than three decades ago, in March 1996.

Two irrigation milestones in one week neatly capture the transformation of Andhra Pradesh’s longest-serving political leader: from the “CEO chief minister” who put Hyderabad on the global technology map to a chief minister increasingly seeking to be remembered as the state’s “Water Man”. Water has, in fact, been a constant in Naidu’s political career, even when technology and investment dominated his image.

FIRST EXPERIMENT

Naidu’s first big experiment was not a mega dam but Kuppam, his political constituency. In the 1990s, he promoted drip irrigation, horticulture and dairy, introducing Israeli drip technology to farmers accustomed to rain-fed agriculture. The system saved an estimated 30-50% of water while improving yields. Sericulture, poultry and dairy followed, turning



FILE PHOTO

agriculture into a more diversified source of income. That philosophy has travelled through successive governments and projects. In 2015, Naidu’s Pattiseema project linked the Godavari and Krishna basins, enabling surplus Godavari water to be transferred towards the Krishna delta.

WATER POLITICS

But Naidu’s current political pitch is different. It is no longer about announcing individual projects, but about creating a system — completing old projects, repairing existing infrastructure and imposing deadlines.

The 2026 Irrigation Calendar exemplifies this approach. Thirty-six priority projects, involving an estimated ₹35,555 crore, have been assigned completion targets between 2026 and December 2028.

The emphasis extends beyond big-ticket construction. Under Jala Dhara—Jala Harathi, launched in April, the government has identified more than 82,000 water-conservation works involving tanks, canals, check dams, farm ponds and groundwater recharge.

There is also unfinished business from Naidu’s earlier innings. Veligonda is finally delivering irrigation and drinking water. Polavaram, which he pushed as a national project, remains the centrepiece of his water strategy. The government says 89% of the works were completed during 2014-19 and 2024-26, with the target of full completion by March 2027.

The numbers matter politically because water has always been Andhra Pradesh’s most difficult development equation—linking agriculture, drought, regional disparities, industry and drinking water. Veligonda inauguration triggered a war of words between the ruling TDP and the Opposition.

YSRCP chief Jagan Mohan Reddy accused Naidu of stealing credit. In a post on X, Reddy wrote, “... @ncbn garu, the history of Veligonda is crystal clear: The foundation stone alone was yours. The vision and comprehensive development of the project belonged to YSR garu. The crucial twin tunnels were completed during our government. What you are doing now is simply stealing the credit.”

For a leader whose first political reinvention was as India’s original technology-friendly CEO CM, Naidu is reinventing himself as Andhra Pradesh’s “Water Man”. The computer screens of Cyberabad have given way to canals, reservoirs and water calendars.

The message from Amaravati is clear: in this innings, Naidu wants his legacy to flow through water.

AFTER PENGUIN RANDOM HOUSE INDIA ROW

HarperCollins to Publish Sonia Gandhi’s Memoir in India on Nov 10

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: HarperCollins India on Friday announced it will publish Congress leader Sonia Gandhi’s memoir, ‘Belonging: A Journey of Love’, in India on November 10.

“One of the most anticipated political memoirs of our time, Belonging is a dramatic and deeply personal story of love, identity, duty and belonging, and offers a rare insider’s view of India’s journey,” the publisher said.



The development came close on the heels of a row over Penguin Random House India deciding not to publish the book in India following reported differences over certain draft contents. Last month, Alfred A. Knopf announced it would publish Gandhi’s memoir globally on the same day. The book has evoked much curiosity given that the 79-year-old Gandhi, currently the chairperson of Congress Parliamentary Party, has been in the thick of India politics ever since she became the party president in 1998. She held the post consecutively for about a record two decades, before returning to lead the party during 2019-22 as its interim president. She also held the all-powerful offices of the chairperson of the ruling UPA and National Advisory Council from 2004-14 during the Manmohan Singh government.

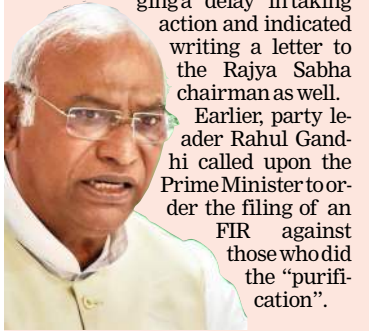
‘Purification’ Row: Cong MPs to Seek Meeting with President Murmu

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Congress members of both Houses of Parliament are planning to request a meeting with President Droupadi Murmu to seek her intervention in the issue of alleged “purification” act at the Haldwani Ramliha Ground, after party president Mallikarjun Kharge addressed a rally there, people aware of the matter said.

Following the leadership’s decision, Congress representatives on Friday evening were in the process of sending a letter to the President, seeking an early date for the MPs, including the Gandhis, to meet her. Condemning the alleged incident as an act of “practising untouchability”, the Congress leadership has been seeking the filing of an FIR against the guilty.

Earlier, party leader Rahul Gandhi called upon the Prime Minister to order the filing of an FIR against those who did the “purification”.



ALLEGED HURRIED CREMATION OF RG KAR RAPE & MURDER VICTIM

RG Kar Case: Ex-Panihati Civic Chairman Arrested

Our Political Bureau

Kolkata: The West Bengal Police arrested Trinamool Congress leader Somnath Dey, former chairman of the Panihati municipality in North 24 Parganas, from Bengaluru in connection with the alleged hurried cremation of the young doctor who was found raped and murdered at the RG Kar Medical College in August 2024.

The police arrested Dey on Thursday, and when he was brought to the Khardah police station on Friday, people gathered there hurled eggs at him. Earlier, he was produced in a Bengaluru court and then brought to Kolkata on a transit remand.

Dey is the third Trinamool Congress leader to be arrested in this case, after chief minister Suvenudra Adhikari ordered a fresh probe on the cremation issue. The state police also arrested former assembly chief whip Nirmal Ghosh from Odisha and former Trinamool councillor Sanjeev Mukherjee from Chinar Park in Kolkata in mid-August.

Abhishek Office Building Gets Evacuation Order from Fire Dept

Kolkata: The West Bengal Fire Department on Friday ordered that the basement and two floors of a high-rise building, housing TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee’s office on Camac Street, be vacated over “lack of fire safety measures”. Letters have been sent by the Director-in-Charge Fire and Emergency Services Department to the owner, Rama Devi Goenka, and her law firm following a recent fire audit. They have been directed “not to use the said occupancy until and unless the fire safety measures are complied with.” — OPB

The Barrackpore Police Commissioner registered an FIR in the case based on a complaint by the victim’s father. He alleged that the accused were present at his house where his daughter’s body was first brought and exerted pressure on the family to take it to the crematorium despite their unwillingness to do so.

Explosion Outside Manipur CLP Leader’s Residence in Thoubal

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: A hand grenade exploded near the gate of Manipur Congress Legislature Party (CLP) leader Keisham Megha-chandra Singh’s residence in Thoubal district. A senior police officer said the explosion took place at Yairipok Bishnunah under Yairipok police station at around 8.15 pm on Thursday. “The identity and motive of

the perpetrator are yet to be established,” the officer said. Soon after the incident, police personnel rushed to the spot and launched a search operation in the area. “We, the Meira Paibi (womenfolk body) of Yairipok Bishnunah, strongly condemn the bomb blast in the residential area. Such acts of violence are unacceptable at a time when people of the state have already been suffering for the past few years,” a woman of the locality said.

Eyes on Power Transfer Unit

►► From Page 1

The airline has also started voluntary testing of all its pilots and said it has “zero tolerance” for any breach of safety, fitness or regulatory requirements.

The three hydraulic systems, which operate independently, lost pressure within seconds while the aircraft was in cruise. Aviation safety expert Captain John Cox, president and CEO of Safety Operating Systems LLC and a former A320 captain, said the simultaneous failure was highly unusual.

“The remote idea that three hydraulic systems are going to fail simultaneously goes against everything I know about how airliners are designed and built,” he said.

The aircraft detected a loss of the green hydraulic system at 04:02:43 UTC (9:32 am IST), followed four seconds later by that of the blue and yellow systems. The autopilot disengaged, a continuous repetitive chime sounded and a stall warning followed for two seconds.

The co-pilot, who was flying the aircraft, initially responded before the pilot-in-command took control. The aircraft climbed 372 feet above its assigned altitude and then fell 292 feet.

The blue hydraulic system recovered first, followed within seconds by the yellow and green systems, after which the flight-control surfaces recovered and normal operation resumed.

David Soucie, a former US Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) safety inspector, said investigators need to establish what could have affected three normally independent systems within seconds and then allowed all three to recover. “I would want to determine whether we experienced three genuine pressure losses or whether there was a common electrical, sensing, control or indication event,” he said.

The aircraft had been dispatched from

Phuket with a Minimum Equipment List item relating to its Power Transfer Unit, which had been invoked on July 28. The investigation has not established whether the PTU issue was connected to the hydraulic failure. Source said investigators should also examine the aircraft’s maintenance history and the deferred PTU.

The aircraft sustained damage to overhead bins, ceiling panels, handrails and other cabin components.

Both pilots passed their post-flight, breath-analyser tests. The pilot-in-command

PROTOCOL IN PLACE

Airline also started testing of all its pilots and said it has “zero tolerance” for any breach of safety, fitness or regulatory requirements

mand’s psychoactive-substance screening test was non-negative, as was the confirmatory blood test. The co-pilot tested negative for both.

The crew chose to continue to Delhi rather than divert to the nearest airport en route and later requested medical priority from air traffic control. The aircraft landed safely at Indira Gandhi International Airport at 05:30 UTC (11 am IST).

Captain Amit Singh, founder and director of Safety Matters Foundation, said the occurrence had correctly been classified as an accident but questioned the level of new technical information in the report.

“There is no new information that has been provided in this report than what was available in the first week.

Expansion Beyond Metros

►► From Page 1

“The company got to know about it sometime in April, following which Arora and a few others were asked to leave with immediate effect,” the person said.

PVR INOX did not respond to questions sent by ET. WhatsApp messages sent to Pramod Arora were not answered until the publication of this report. ET could not independently establish the identities of the developers allegedly involved in the kickbacks scandal.

As part of the PVR INOX merger contract, Ajay Bijli is responsible for running the company for the first five years starting March 2022, when the union was announced.

Arora played a key role in PVR’s expansion into Tier II and Tier III markets through asset-light formats, including franchisee-owned, company-operated (FOCO) cinemas and the SMART/

Smart Screen initiative.

These formats offer lower-priced, digital-first multiplexes aimed at value-conscious audiences in smaller towns.

PVR INOX, India’s largest multiplex chain, was created through the 2023 merger of PVR and INOX Leisure. As of late August, it operated 1,786 screens across 356 properties in 113 cities in India and Sri Lanka. The company plans to add another 1,000 screens over the next five years, largely through franchise-led expansion.

The allegations come as PVR INOX’s financial performance has improved. The company reported consolidated net profit of ₹56.5 crore in the April-June quarter of FY27, compared with a

loss of ₹54.5 crore a year earlier. Revenue from operations rose 11.9% year-on-year to ₹1,622.2 crore, while Ebitda increased 30.8% to ₹528 crore.

Its Ebitda margin expanded to 32.5%, helped by higher occupancy, a stronger film slate and increased contributions from advertising and food and beverage.

PVR INOX had net cash of ₹80.7 crore at the end of the quarter. Its board has also approved a ₹300-crore share buy-back at ₹1,450 a share.

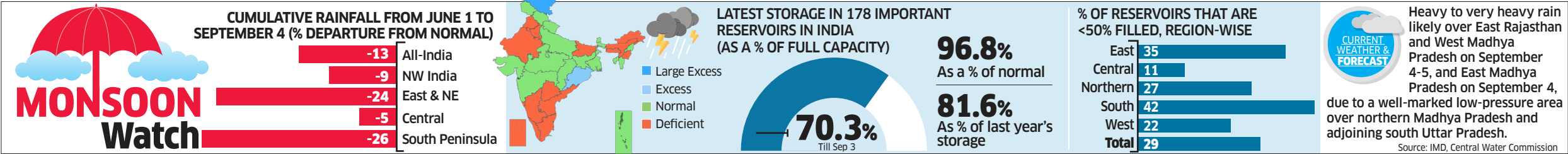
Promoters hold about 27.5% in the company, with the remaining stake held by foreign investors, domestic institutions and public shareholders.

According to a declaration signed by Arora, he was restricted from joining rival cinema chains and from contacting PVR INOX’s existing vendors. The declaration also provides for potential legal action in the event of a breach.

(With inputs from Javed Farooqui and Rajesh Naidu in Mumbai)

SEAMLESS CONNECTIVITY Aims to complete multi-modal transport network a year ahead of schedule

The jobs data “confirms that CPI is the relevant data point,” said Marco Oviedo, strategist at XP Invertementos. “If CPI comes in as expected, with lower annual core inflation, I believe a Fed pause could be guaranteed. Until then, I don’t expect any major moves.” On Thursday, Fed Governor Christopher Waller said he’d support holding policy rate if there was



New FTAs Open Big Export Gains Across Key Sectors

Electronics, agri and gems & jewellery among sectors with biggest opportunities

Kirtika Suneja

New Delhi: Eight new free trade agreements (FTAs) signed in the last five years have opened up duty-free market access of \$982 billion in electronics, \$631 billion in agriculture, and \$442 billion in gems and jewellery for Indian exporters, according to an analysis by the commerce and industry ministry.

Engineering goods, chemicals and pharmaceuticals are the other manufacturing sectors where the market opportunity is high. Two of the trade deals, with New Zealand and the EU, are yet to be operational.

The analysis covered trade pacts with the UK, UAE, Oman, Australia, European Free Trade Association (EFTA) and Mauritius. EFTA comprises Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway and Switzerland.

The analysis showed the EU's imported \$6.62 trillion worth of goods in 2024, but India's share was only a meagre 1.23%. The India-EU FTA is expected to come into force next year.

Similarly, the UK's merchandise imports from the world were \$815.6 billion but India's share was only 1.88%. The engineering goods sector offers a whopping \$3 trillion opportunity while labour-intensive sectors such as marine and leather each have a \$70 billion-plus market opportunity in these new markets.

Officials said strong growth across manufacturing, engineering goods, electronics, chemicals, pharmaceuticals, food products and consumer goods has enabled exporters to capitalise on opportunities created by trade deals and expanding domestic competitiveness. "A key feature of the current export performance is the diversification of markets beyond traditional destinations," said an official. "It helps export resilience by reducing dependence on a limited set of destinations and increasing India's participation across multiple regional value chains." The new trade pacts provide 100% duty-free market access to most Indian products of labour intensive sectors, leading to trade expansion. Consider this: India's goods exports to the UAE rose to \$37.3 billion in FY26, from \$28 billion in FY22, buoyed by higher silk, machinery and carpet shipments.

The India-UAE Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement came into effect May 1, 2022, while to EFTA, the outbound shipments were stable at around \$1.7 billion.

However, exports to Australia fell to \$7.3 billion in 2025-26 from \$8.3 billion in FY22 though food products and pharmaceutical exports have grown. The India-Australia Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement entered into force on December 29, 2022.

India's trade deficit with Australia reduced to \$6.5 billion last fiscal from \$8.5 billion in FY22, per official data. With Mauritius, India's goods trade surplus shrank to \$374.66 million from \$643 million in the same period.

"One needs to see the quality of trade imbalance," the official said, adding that lot a lot of time, raw material imports are used for manufacturing and exports.

Opportunity Galore

Across 8 new FTAs in last five years

Duty-free market access (\$ b)

Agri	631
Textile & apparel	359
Gems & jewellery	442
Engg goods	2,997
Electronics	982
Pharma	547

Significant rise in exports to these countries

	2021-22	2025-26	2021-22	2025-26
Mauritius	0.7	0.5	0.6	0.4
Australia	8.3	7.3	-8.5	-6.5
EFTA	1.7	1.7	-23.7	-23.2
UK	10.5	13.4	3.4	1.8
New Zealand	0.5	0.6	0.1	(-0.02)
EU	65.0	72.4	13.6	6.3
US	76.2	87.3	32.9	33.8
Oman	3.1	4.0	-3.7	-3.1
UAE	28.0	37.3	-16.7	-26.5

Source: Ministry of Commerce and Industry

Trade pacts with EU, NZ yet to come into force

Trade deal with US under negotiation

Strong growth in key sectors helps exporters tap trade-deal gains and leverage domestic competitiveness, officials said

No Takers Yet for ₹37,500 cr Coal Gasification Scheme

New Delhi: The government's ambitious ₹37,500-crore financial incentive scheme for the promotion of coal gasification has found no taker so far, according to sources.

Despite the September 7 deadline, the scheme has received no application from any private or public player to set up projects under the programme, raising concerns over the viability of the coal ministry's push to gasify 75 million tonnes of coal and lignite, sources said.

Unless the deadline of September 7 is over, it would not be possible to state the number of applications since the whole process is online, the coal ministry said in an emailed response.

The ministry has received communication from several industries expressing interest in participating in the scheme, it said.

In a notice, the coal ministry had said that "the Request for Proposal (RFP) dated July 7, 2026, issued under the ₹37,500 crore financial incentive scheme for promotion of surface coal/lignite gasification projects, wherein the last date for submission of applications is September 7, 2026."

It is pertinent to inform that given the scale of funds involved in coal gasification projects, the preparation of PFRs and project proposals requires time, the ministry said, adding that application rounds are envisaged every two months, providing multiple opportunities for industry participation.

The Union Cabinet had earlier approved the scheme to promote coal gasification projects, aimed at boosting clean energy production and reducing dependence on forex-guzzling imports of LNG, urea, and methanol, while insulating the country from global price volatility and supply chain disruptions.

The Union Cabinet under the chairmanship of Prime Minister Narendra Modi approved the scheme for promotion of surface coal/lignite gasification projects with a financial outlay of ₹37,500 crore. —PTI

'Insurance Claim Can't be Rejected if Alcohol Habit Disclosed'

PTI

Mumbai: A Nagpur consumer commission has directed a life insurance company to pay over ₹50 lakh to a widow, ruling that rejecting a claim when the deceased had already disclosed his alcohol consumption habit prior to buying the policy amounts to deficiency in service.

Further, relying on Supreme Court orders that termed hypertension and diabetes mellitus as lifestyle diseases, the forum noted that the claim cannot be denied merely because a person did not mention these pre-existing diseases before taking the policy.

The District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission (Nagpur), in an order passed last month, held Edelweiss Tokio Life Insurance Company Limited guilty of deficiency in service for rejecting the legally payable insurance claim of the complainant's husband.

As per the complainant, her husband had purchased the insurance company's policy in April 2021. Following his sudden death on January 26, 2023, the widow filed an insurance claim.

However, the insurance firm subsequently rejected the claim, cancelled the policy, and sent a premium refund cheque of ₹18,713 in September 2023. The woman then approached the District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission.

Customs Portal Aims to Curb Divergent Assessment Practices

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) has launched a common digital repository of customs assessment decisions, rulings and advisories, giving importers and customs brokers access to a searchable database, a move aimed at reducing divergent practices across customs formations.

The National Assessment Centre (NAC) Portal is expected to provide greater certainty to industry on how similar products and transactions are being assessed across the country. The move is significant for businesses importing goods that have historically faced differing classifications or valuation approaches at different ports.

A common repository of precedents could allow companies to identify the prevailing assessment position and strengthen their submissions when seeking a particular classification or valuation treatment.

Importers will be able to search previous decisions and guidance before filing declarations or responding to assessment queries, potentially reducing delays, representations and litigation arising from inconsistent interpretations.

The portal, available at naccustoms.gov.in, brings together Customs Authority for Advance Rulings (CAAR) rulings, legal decisions, audit objections, NAC advisories and alerts, as well as information on classification, valuation and other assessment-related issues. The initiative is the latest step in the customs reforms to promote uniformity and consistency in customs assessment.

"This would promote better compliance, reduce avoidable divergent interpretations and practices, and provide greater transparency and certainty to trade," the CBIC said in a circular issued on Friday.

At the same time, for customs officers, the portal is intended to provide a common reference base for assessment decisions, helping prevent repeated examination of issues that have already been settled or considered by another formation. The portal will also carry other relevant details of policy issues related to customs, commissioner level facilitation committees and permanent trade facilitation committees.

The CBIC has directed NACs to update the portal regularly with issues raised by stakeholders with their credentials at a regular interval.

New RE Units May Need to Store 10% Power for 2 Hours

New Delhi: The Central Electricity Authority (CEA), under the power ministry, has proposed mandatorily storing energy for at least two hours and equivalent to at least 10% of the installed capacity for new solar and wind projects.

The move brings the needs of utilities and industries to the front by adding storage to renewable energy projects for ensuring firm and continuous power.

According to the draft amendment to the Central Electricity Authority (Technical Standards for Construction of Electric Plants and Electric Lines) Regulations, plants commissioned from July 2027 are required to install the co-located storage.

For instance, a 100 MW solar project would need at least 10 MW of co-located storage with a two-hour duration. The comments are to be submitted by October 4. "While the capex for a renewable energy developer will go up, the project itself should help in predictable dispatch of power which could overall improve the revenues from the project," Sujoy Ghosh, vice president and country managing director-India at First Solar told ET.

Last year, CEA had issued an advisory on colocation of energy storage with solar power projects, with similar recommendations to improve dispatchability of solar power. The proposed amendments however make it mandatory under the regulations. Most power utilities, commercial and industrial users and renewable energy developers have already been tendering and building green energy projects with storage to enable more reliable electricity. The proposed rules also raised the storage duration requirement for projects commissioned from July 1, 2029, to June 30, 2031. —Our Bureau

GST Returns, Overseas Investments, Off-mkt Stock Deal Come under AIS

Anuradha Shukla

New Delhi: The Income Tax Department is broadening the scope of financial information required for taxpayers' annual information statements (AIS), bringing goods and services tax (GST) returns, foreign remittances for investment in mutual funds outside banking channels, and off-market securities transactions under the data net.

The department is also allowing relevant information from another taxpayer's income tax return besides ongoing and completed tax proceedings to get reflected in the AIS.

While data on normal remittances through legal banking channels is already available with the tax department through tax deducted at source (TDS) provision, the additional information will also tap investment in derivative markets and unlisted companies overseas through brokers and overseas agents which used to escape the income tax net earlier.

The Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) has also authorised the Director General of Income Tax (Systems) to upload this information within three months from the end of the month in which it's received, according to the latest framework being prepared.

"The expanded data pool strengthens the department's ability to match income and transactions declared in tax returns with information generated elsewhere, increasing the possibility of discrepancies being flagged during tax-compliance checks," a senior official told ET.

The information will be used in the current scrutiny cycle and the next filing cycle, making tax evasion difficult for both companies. The sweep extends beyond transactions and information reported to the government by multiple agencies and financial intermediaries.

For instance, while data was already shared between GST and the IT department, it was used only in cases under scrutiny. Henceforth, the direct inflow of the transaction in the AIS is likely to nudge taxpayers to report income more accurately.

For investors, AIS can capture off-market transactions reported by depositories or registrars and transfer agents, dividends and mutual fund purchases reported by registrar and transfer agents (RTAs).

"The changes are made on the basis of analysis of tax evasion instances, and with the advanced data analytics being fully functional, evasion will become extremely difficult," the official said. "Going forward, more data will be reflected, including donations, giving taxpayers enough information to report their income correctly."

The provision allowing information contained in another taxpayer's ITR to be reflected in AIS is particularly significant. It gives the tax department a mechanism to bring relevant information reported in one taxpayer's return into the information trail of another taxpayer.

In the last three years, the department has widely expanded the data pool that goes into AIS, strengthening its ability to match income and transactions declared in tax returns with information generated elsewhere, increasing the possibility of discrepancies being flagged during tax compliance checks. This year, the department has included information regarding foreign income for filing returns.

Taxpayers will get a chance to contest information, if they find it incorrect. The income tax portal already allows taxpayers to view AIS through website or taxpayer mobile application and submit feedback if an entry is incorrect or duplicated. Responses can also be submitted through the department's offline utility.

Wider Ambit

Information relating to GST return

Information relating to Specified Financial Transactions (SFT)

Foreign remittance information beyond TDS, TCS via RTAs, tax information exchange

Off Market Transactions Reported by Depository/Registrar and Transfer Agent

Information in the ITR of other taxpayers

Information received from any other person deemed fit in the interest of the revenue

Information relating to pending, completed proceedings

Information received from any officer, authority under an agreement with the tax department

TIMES INTERNET

HOME & DECOR AWARDS 2026

CELEBRATING EVERYDAY LIVING BUILT BY CREATIVITY

From design and decor to the brands and products shaping modern homes - honouring excellence across every category.



INDUSTRY-WIDE RECOGNITION



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WIDE MEDIA VISIBILITY



BENCHMARK YOUR BRAND

30+ AWARD CATEGORIES

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ARCHITECT OF THE YEAR



INTERIOR DESIGNER OF THE YEAR



BEST LUXURY RESIDENCE



LIGHTING BRAND

SCAN TO NOMINATE



LAST DATE TO NOMINATE

16TH SEPTEMBER 2026

 toi.in/homedecorawards

Will RIL's Next Big Scoop Melt Market?

Entry into icecream biz taps consumption surge

Reliance Consumer Products, an arm of Mukesh Ambani's diversifying business conglomerate, will enter the ice-cream business, with its own brand, Bombay Creamery. Ambani is known to go up against dominant players in industries, such as oil refining, telecom and even colas. This makes the foray into the icecream business that is led by a dairy farmers' cooperative unusual. Yet, Indian business families have a penchant for building diversified groups. The Ambanis have been outliers in this respect with their focus on a few basic industries where they have integrated vertically. Yet, for a group the size of Reliance must see the merits of expansion into unrelated businesses.

Operating across different industries lowers the risk of specific market downturns. Diversified groups can allocate capital freely to new businesses. Shared resources can bring down operating costs across divisions. On the

flip side, running multiple businesses can affect decision-making timelines. Management bandwidth is spread over a wider canvas and could lead to a loss of focus on core operations. Harnessing separate corporate cultures can reduce business value. Investors tend to value diversified conglomerates less than the sum of their parts. It is often more efficient to diversify an investment portfolio than seek the same results through a conglomerate.

Some degree of corporate diversification can be attributed to India's status as a frontline emerging economy that throws up high growth opportunities across a range of industries. Consumption is an obvious theme in the larger India story and has drawn in some of the biggest business groups. Corporate interest is climbing in segments as disparate as housing, food, entertainment and fashion. India needs its own champions in lifestyle brands, and its business barons are ready for the challenge. The consumer space can yield considerable market shares to local brands that can go toe-to-toe with global ones that dominate the landscape. Icecream is as good a place as any to build a truly international brand from India.

Curing Our Broken, Disturbing Roads

A road is only as good as the system that builds and maintains it. India has specifications for road construction. Too often, the distance between what's prescribed on paper and what gets built is measured in potholes, patchwork and pending repairs. NHAI's move to make AI-based machine control (AI-MC) compulsory for highway projects is welcome. Using sensors, computers and real-time data to ensure every layer is built to specification can bring precision, accountability and consistency to 'street credentials'.

There will be an upfront cost. But if better construction means roads that last longer, need fewer repairs and reduce accidents, the investment can pay for itself. In 2025, 62,122 people died on

NHs. Better-engineered roads can't eliminate accidents. But quality is vital to road safety and comfort. Good roads move trucks more efficiently, and reduce fuel use, travel time and logistics costs. A Transport Corporation of India (TCI)-IIM Kolkata study estimated that poor road conditions, delays and frequent halts cost India \$21.3 bn a year — \$6.6 bn in delays and \$14.7 bn in added fuel consumption.

We tend to measure infra in kilometres of highways and billions of rupees. But development — 'viksit' in today's jargon — is experienced on the road outside one's home, on the street to the market, or en route to school. Roads are among the most visible markers of development. NHAI's embrace of tech should extend to city roads, arterial roads and neighbourhood streets, where potholes, shoddy patchwork, poor drainage and constant digging remain common. We need not just better roads, but a culture of moving away from a 'vendor-tender' culture, and of monitoring roads *before* they become laughable definitions of what city roads should be.



THINK ABOUT IT

Leela – play – drives all creativity, even if the players don't know it

Playcore, Lying at the Heart of Creativity

Human creativity, that serious stuff, is built on the least serious of foundations: play. Strip away the jargon of innovation labs, the solemnity of TED talks and the furrowed brows of venture capitalists, and what remains is the same impulse that drives toddlers to stack blocks, and comedians to deliver punchlines. Playfulness isn't a distraction from creativity but its beating heart. The best innovators are players. They may wear suits, gather patents or Nobel Prizes. But underneath, they are children with expensive toys. Thomas Edison tinkered like a boy with a chemistry set. Picasso doodled like a prankster with a spray can. Even Einstein admitted his theory of relativity was born of 'thought experiments' — a fancy way of saying he played with ideas until they popped up proper.

Play comes in two flavours: frivolous and serious. Frivolous play invents Monopoly, Insta reels and government policy in the form of alliterations. Serious play invents vaccines, space travel and nation states. Without frivolity, creativity becomes sterile, ritualistic, dogmatic. Without seriousness, it can't move beyond silly-hood. Together, they produce the kind of breakthroughs that make life richer, stranger and, yes, profitable. Many innovators deny they are playing. They prefer to call it 'research', 'business' or 'disruption'. But who are they kidding?

We need mandatory, evidence-based front-of-pack labels consumers can understand instantly



Rohit Kumar Singh

Walk into any supermarket and pick up a packet of biscuits, cereal or chips. Front-of-pack labelling (FOPL) is a masterpiece in communication: attractive colours, catchy claims, endorsements, photographs, and promises of health, energy or goodness. But nutritional reality is usually relegated to a small table on the back. That asymmetry needs to change.

The debate over FOPL has gained urgency after an investigative report said that India's efforts to introduce prominent warnings for products high in sugar, salt and fat faced opposition from sections of the food and beverage industry. The industry has since said India should consult companies while framing new FOPL rules.

Industry should be consulted. Manufacturers understand formulations, supply chains, packaging constraints and consumer behaviour, and their inputs can improve implementation. But consultation cannot become a veto. The key purpose of food labelling is not to protect the packet's appearance. It is to protect the consumer's right to make an informed choice.

India is witnessing a rapid nutrition transition. The country continues to deal with under-nutrition while facing an expanding burden of obesity, diabetes, hypertension and cardiovascular disease. Against this background, requiring consumers to decipher percentages, serving sizes, and grams of sugar and mg of sodium from a dense nutrition panel is inadequate.

There is an important distinction between providing information and making information understandable. Existing nutrition tables may satisfy the first test. Effective FOPL satisfies the second. A person buying breakfast cereal should not ne-

Let's Know What We Eat



Sauce for home food is sauce for packaged food

ed a degree in nutrition to work out whether it is unusually high in sugar.

WHO describes FOPL as an important policy tool to help consumers make healthier food choices. It recommends that governments introduce nutrition declarations and supplement them with FOP information that is convenient, relevant and readily understood. It also points to another important benefit: well-designed labelling can encourage manufacturers to reformulate products. That second effect is often underestimated.

The biggest benefit of a strong labelling regime may eventually come not from consumers rejecting products but from manufacturers changing them. If a visible label tells consumers that one product has significantly more sugar or salt than another, competition begins to work in favour of public health. Companies have an incentive to innovate, reduce undesirable ingredients and improve their nutritional profile. The market then becomes part of the solution.

Consistency is also a question. Nestlé says it has implemented Nutri-Score on thousands of products across continental Europe. Nutri-Score uses a simple 5-colour scale from A to E to help consumers compare nutritional quality. Such labelling helps people make informed choices and encourages the company to improve the nutritional value of its products.

This makes the Indian debate difficult to explain. If an easily understandable nutritional label helps consumers in France, Germany or Belgium make informed choices, why should an Indian consumer be expected to manage with less?

This is not an argument for mechanically importing a European system. India's food habits, dietary patterns, literacy levels and market structure are different. We need a system designed for India. The debate should not be reduced to whether India must adopt a particular colour, symbol or scoring methodology. There are legitimate scientific questions around nutrient thresholds and portion sizes, and whether labels should provide warnings or comparative scores. These questions should be settled through evidence.

FSSAI should commission transparent consumer-testing across regions, languages, income groups and education levels. Nutrition scientists, public

health experts, consumer organisations and industry should participate. The scientific basis for thresholds should be published. The selected label should then be simple enough for an ordinary consumer to understand instantly. The final system must also be mandatory.

Voluntary labelling inevitably creates an adverse-selection problem. Companies with healthier products have an incentive to display favourable information. Those with products high in sugar, salt or saturated fat may have precisely the opposite incentive.

A common standard creates a level playing field.

Industry concerns about transition costs are legitimate and can be addressed through reasonable implementation timelines. Smaller manufacturers may require greater flexibility and technical support. Regulation should always be proportionate. But the principle itself should not be compromised.

Indeed, FOPL should not be viewed as anti-industry. India's food-processing sector is one of the country's important growth opportunities. Stronger consumer standards can increase trust, encourage innovation and push Indian companies towards products that can compete globally. Consumers, meanwhile, remain free to choose.

India has spent years strengthening consumer empowerment through



It is reasonable to reserve a small part of the front of a food package for the truth about what is inside

gh better disclosure, digital access and more competitive markets. Food cannot remain an exception. The front of a food package today is some of the most valuable advertising real estate in the consumer economy. Almost every centimetre is carefully designed to influence the purchasing decision.

It is reasonable to reserve a small part of that space for the truth about what is inside. FOP cannot belong entirely to marketing. Some of it must belong to the consumer, too.

The writer is former secretary, ministry of consumer affairs, food & public distribution, GoI

Curb Misselling, Not Agents



Sriram Kalyanaraman

Ask anyone who was sold a 'guaranteed wealth-builder' and later tried to escape it. The product was costly, unsuitable and locked shut. That is misselling, and it is not rare. It usually begins with one broken incentive: when a seller earns almost everything from the first sale, the complicated, high-commission policy gets sold rather than the simple one the customer needed.

So, IRDAI's instinct to rethink how intermediaries are paid is sound. The regulator wants lower distribution costs, more policies that stay alive, and better value for buyers. The worry is not the goal. It is whether the fix damages the network that reaches ordinary Indians in the first place.

Two proposals are in play. One spreads the commission across the life of the policy instead of front-loading it. The other ties pay to an agent's 'effort' in sourcing and serving customers. Both are meant to protect the buyer. Both also add complexity to a system

that runs on pay being simple and predictable.

Individual agents still bring in roughly 51% of individual new-business premium. Banks, through bancassurance, account for about 33%, and the rest comes from direct, online and broker channels. Two decades ago, agents wrote nearly 90% of the business, so the shift to banks has been dramatic. LIC remains agent-heavy, while most private insurers lean on their bank partners.

That split matters because the conduct risk is not spread evenly.

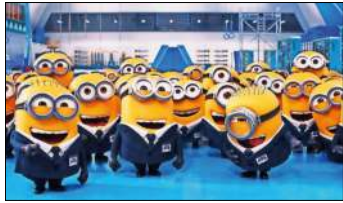
► In 2024-25, life insurers sold about 2.70 cr new individual policies, LIC sold 1.78 cr of those, private insurers sold about 92.5 lakh.

► Complaints filed under unfair business practices rose to 26,667, from 23,335 a year earlier — up roughly 14%.

What makes that stand out is the backdrop. Total life complaints barely moved, from 1,20,726 to 1,20,429. The pie stayed the same size while the misselling slice grew from about 19% to 22%. Set 26,667 against 2.70 cr new policies, and it is close to 1 in 1,000.

Although the share is small, the trend is negative and reflects issues with the sale process.

Here are the parts reformers should sit with. Much of the loudest misselling has come from bank counters —



Cherish the network

policies dressed up as FDs or quietly bundled into loans. One hears a lot of misselling in bundled loans. Both FM and IRDAI chief said as much in 2024. Yet, commission reform lands hardest on the individual agent, whose pay is visible and straightforward to cut, not on the bank channel, where the incentive is buried in a wider banking relationship. Squeeze the agent, who is an easier target, and you may leave the bigger problem untouched.

The reforms could also backfire where India can least afford it. Life insurance still reaches under 3% of GDP, and crores of Indians hold no cover at all. That last mile runs on roughly 26 lakh individual agents, most working in small towns and villages where a policy is sold across a kitchen table, not a screen. For them, the upfront commission is working capital — it pays the bus fare, the repeat visits, and the hours spent explaining what a policy does.

Every GW Saved is a GW Earned



Samir Saran & Parul Bakshi

Indian philosophical traditions have long warned against excess without rejecting prosperity. 'Aparigraha', restraint in possession, does not demand denial but calls for mindful use. Reimagined for a modern energy economy, it offers a strategic insight: efficiency is not austerity but disciplined abundance.

As India engages with another season of record electricity demand — with peak power requirement expected to touch 300 GW in 2027 — the policy instinct is familiar: more generation, stronger grids, larger storage, faster transmission. However, in an era shaped by climate extremes and geopolitical uncertainty, how well a nation uses energy may matter as much as how much it produces.

India's rising energy demand is a marker of development. Per-capita electricity consumption climbed to about 1,538 kWh in 2025, and demand is projected to grow a further 6% annually this decade. Cooling demand alone could account for nearly 1/3rd of peak load by 2030, with peak demand rising by more than 7 GW for every additional degree of daily average temperature.

Without major efficiency gains in buildings, appliances and cooling, this risks locking in higher generati-

on needs and deeper grid stress for decades, since what is built today shapes demand for a generation. Efficiency is now a time-critical determinant of whether India's energy future now stays affordable, stable and secure. The strategic question, therefore, is not whether India should consume more energy, but whether each additional unit can contribute more efficiently towards national growth.

Energy efficiency in India is treated as a technical intervention, rather than an instrument of national strategy. Mega-projects command visibility, financing and urgency; efficiency-driven avoided demand is less politically appealing, although even more vital.

Governance remains fragmented across ministries, regulators, utilities and states, with no institutional centre capable of elevating efficiency to core infrastructure. Capital, too, flows far more readily toward generation than efficient consumption, an imbalance increasingly at odds with fuel shocks, supply disruptions, climate-driven demand spikes and accelerating electrification, all redefining energy security.

In such a landscape, the most strategic unit of energy is not the MW newly produced but the MW never required. Saved energy is immediate, domestic and largely immune to geopolitical risk, an instrument of resilience and sovereign power that determines not only how India grows but

how securely it does.

Energy security is often framed through availability, accessibility, affordability and acceptability. Efficiency is one of the few interventions capable of strengthening all 4 at once.

► **Availability** Rapid growth in cooling demand could push ACs alone to account for close to 30% of projected electricity needs. According to some calculations, stronger efficiency standards can help avoid up to 60 GW of peak demand while saving consumers tens of billions of dollars. In effect, efficiency creates new 'virtual capacity' faster and more economically.

► **Accessibility and affordability** Efficient appliances and cooling technologies cut household bills and system-wide costs, while lower peak demand reduces the need for costly backup generation, storage and grid expansion. UJALA illustrates the potential, where more than 36 cr LED bulbs have generated 48 bn kWh in annual savings and cut consumer expenditure by over ₹19,000 cr each year. Acceptability, the climate dimension, follows naturally: meeting cooling and comfort needs with less energy cuts emissions and infrastructure pressure without constraining growth.

► **Acceptability** India has built a broad efficiency policy ecosystem. Programmes such as UJALA LED, the market-based Perform, Achieve and Trade (PAT) scheme, and Standards and Labelling have demonstrated the potential of



Tap the energy

demand-side efficiency at scale, while the Energy Conservation Building Code, Eco-Niwas Samhita, and Green Rating for Integrated Habitat Assessment have sought to embed efficiency into the buildings shaping India's urban future. India already has many of the tools. Few strategies improve all 4 pillars of energy security with comparable speed and economic logic. That combination makes efficiency foundational to energy policy, that is forward-looking.

If efficiency is to function as infrastructure rather than aspiration, India must move from dispersed programmes to deliberate strategy, in 3 steps:

- Embed efficiency explicitly within India's energy-security architecture, alongside generation, grids and storage, as a core planning resource.
- Govern the coming wave of urban construction, cooling deployment and digital infrastructure with performance standards that prevent decades of inefficient demand from locking into the system.
- Accelerate market mechanisms, from demand response and utility incentives to scalable financing, so private capital flows toward optimising consumption with the same confidence as new capacity.

Efficiency is not simply a strategic resource. Every unit saved reduces future infrastructure needs, moderates import dependence and strengthens resilience. Making efficiency strategic is an exercise in long-term statecraft. Nations that learn to do more with less will shape the resilience of the 21st-c. energy order.

Saran is president, and Bakshi is fellow, energy and climate, ORF



AI and Teachers

NEIL VIMALKUMAR

With the possibilities thrown open by AI, can human teachers be replaced? While AI can handle surveys, data processing and analysis far more efficiently, a teacher's role may never be completely replaced by a robot. Here is why. Teaching is far more than transferring data from a teacher to a pupil. As we grow more dependent on virtual teaching platforms, we cannot overlook the inevitability of a personal teacher. In many ancient Asian contexts, gurus and shishyas even lived together as life skills and knowledge were imparted to students. So, the teacher knew the subject matter and also lived an exemplary life worthy of emulation. Integrity meant character matched capability.

John Searle's thought experiment in cognitive philosophy highlights the personal component of human discernment against a machine's proficiency. While AI tools can give us correct responses, they would never be able to 'understand' as they would be focused on the syntax of symbols, and not the semantics of the message. A few decades ago, Michael Polanyi, a philosopher of science, pointed out that even in the scientific institution, there is a tradition of knowledge where everything is not just 'impersonal' data. There is an element of trust, personal knowledge, judgement and social context that cannot be ignored. While AI might bring multiple skills and incredible speeds to the table, we need people to lead people.



Social Media Addict

A man went to the doctor and said, 'Doctor, I think I'm addicted to social media.'

The doctor frowned. 'How long have you had this problem?'

The man immediately pulled out his phone. 'Let me check.' He scrolled for a while. 'Apparently, someone had this exact problem in 2018.'

Doc: And? Man: He was cured. Doc: How? Man: He deleted all his social media apps. Doc [smiles]: Excellent. You can do the same. Man [horrified]: Doctor, I said I'm addicted. I didn't say I was insane!

Marriage Advice

A newly married man asked his grandfather: 'What's the secret to a happy marriage?' Nanaji: 'Never argue with your wife. Grandson: That sounds impossible! Nanaji: It's not. Whenever she's right, agree with her. Grandson: And when she's wrong? Nanaji [smiles]: She's never wrong. Grandson [sighs]: That's your secret? Nanaji: No. My secret is that I've been married for 62 years. Grandson: Exactly. So you must know something. Nanaji: I know when to keep my mouth shut. Grandson: About what? Nanaji: Everything.

Chat Room

Bring Mammon To the Mountain

Appropos 'Trishuli and China Question for Nepal' by Safi Ahsan Rizvi (Sep 4), Nepal's demand for climate compensation is morally compelling but legally and politically contentious. Despite its negligible contribution to global emissions, Nepal faces disproportionate threats from glacier retreat, floods and landslides. Yet, assigning exclusive responsibility for specific losses to India, China or the US remains scientifically difficult, since natural variability, deforestation, unplanned construction and infrastructural deficiencies can exacerbate disasters. Nepal's stronger case lies in demanding predictable multilateral climate finance, adaptation assistance and loss-and-damage support, rather than seeking potentially unlimited bilateral reparations from individual countries. N Sadhasiva Reddy Bengaluru

Top Money Managers Rebuild Gold Holdings

Investors bet long-term drivers of the precious metal will endure despite a more assertive US Fed stance on inflation

Bloomberg

Some of the world's biggest money managers have rebuilt their gold holdings after prices dropped, betting that long-term drivers of the precious metal will endure even as the US Federal Reserve takes a more assertive stance on inflation.

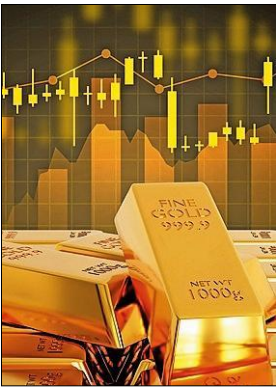
Amundi SA, Europe's largest asset manager, bought bullion on the expectation it will return to \$5,000 an ounce by year-end. Fund managers at Pictet Asset Management, Robeco Institutional Asset Management BV and Fidelity International also added to holdings cut earlier this year, during bullion's retreat from an all-time high.

"Gold is an asset that we consider to be cheap, a good hedge and reasonably liquid," said Lorenzo Portelli, head of cross-asset strategy at Amundi Investment Institute. But greater visibility over the Fed's interest-rate path would be needed, he said, before the firm would consider adding to last month's purchases.

That was a common theme in interviews with more than a dozen asset managers, whose firms manage a combined \$27 trillion. Without exception, each of them—including BNP Paribas Asset Management and Manulife John Hancock Investments—had either added back gold in recent weeks or were maintaining bullish allocations.

But any breakout above gold's recent ceiling near \$4,600 an ounce won't be smooth, many of the money managers said. Higher Treasury yields and increased bets for at least one Fed rate hike before year-end are undermining support for bullion, an asset that tends to be less favoured when borrowing costs rise, because it doesn't pay interest.

Investors' resolve was tested by Fed Chairman Kevin Warsh's August 28 speech at the central bank's Jackson Hole symposium, where he warned that US inflation isn't meaningfully slowing toward



a 2% target—comments that triggered increased bets on monetary tightening. So far, these potential speed bumps haven't shaken the renewed conviction of long-term investors. Gold's enduring appeal, some of the money managers said, lies in its value as a hedge within a broader investment portfolio.

"It's become a much more acceptable asset," said Arnout van Rijn, a portfolio manager for multi-asset and equity solutions at Robeco, a

Dutch firm that oversees some \$464 billion in assets. "It's become part and parcel of every regular or normal portfolio."

After a blistering rally backed by speculative capital took gold to an all-time high near \$5,600 an ounce in January, the metal has spent much of this year in retreat. Elevated energy prices and inflationary shocks from the Iran war dragged it back to near \$4,000 in June. That's when funds began to show interest.

"The downdraft to \$4,000, if you didn't own it already, was a very good buying time," said Michael Cuggino, president of the Permanent Portfolio Family of Funds. "The long-term macro story is still in place, and that's bullish for gold," he said, adding that "higher highs and higher lows" could be expected over time.

RAIL WHEEL FACTORY
Yelbhanika, BANGALORE - 560 064
Website: www.rwfblr@gmail.com
e-mail: smm.rwfblr@gmail.com

Tender Notice No. RWF/S/P2/15/2026-27 dtd 03/09/26

On behalf of the President of India, Principal Chief Materials Manager invites Global E-Tender from OEM/Authorised agents for supply of the following items on Indian Railways e-portal www.ireps.gov.in.

1. Tender No : P2265655, **Description :** Design, Supply, installation & commissioning of Primary Fume Extraction System I & II of EAF A & B on turnkey basis as per technical specification (Qty – 1 Set). **Tender closing date & time:** 05.10.26 @ 14:00 Hrs. **Pre Bid Conference:** 16.09.26 @ 11:00 Hrs.

2. Tender Number : P2265723, **Description :** Supply, installation, commissioning, testing and proving of Automated Motorized Stage Inverted Metallurgical Microscope with Image Analysis Software with all standard, essential & concomitant accessories, consumables, spare parts along with sample Preparation Equipments and CAMC for 5 years as per Technical Specification (Qty – 1 Set). **Tender closing date & time:** 01.10.26 @ 14:00 Hrs.

3. Tender No. : P2265867, **Description:** Provision of CCTV Surveillance system in Factory and AMC for 5 years as per Technical Specification (Qty – 1 Set). **Tender closing date & time:** 29.09.26 @ 14:00 Hrs.

Tender details can be viewed on RWF website or E-Portal. Tender documents & corrigendum (if any), will be available on the E-Portal only.

Principal Chief Materials Manager

BRIHANMUMBAI MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

TENDER NOTICE

Department : Solid Waste Management

Section : Dy.Ch.Eng.(SWM)City

Tender Id No. : 2026_MCGM_1335172_1

Subject : Hiring of 4 Nos. of Skid Steer Loader Machines with combination bucket attachment for collection of refuse at open dumps & GVPs in L Ward for period of one year.

Bid Start Date & Time : 05.09.2026 from 11.00 AM

Pre Bid Date : NA

Bid End Date & Time : 15.09.2026 till 16.00 PM

Website : <https://mahatenders.gov.in>

Contact Person:-

a Name : Shri. Hemant T.Bhusare
A.E.(SWM)Planning

b Telephone : 022-23844450

c Mobile No. : 9762006449

d E-mail Id : ee1swm.pl@mcgm.gov.in

PRO/1330/ADV/2026-27 Sd/-
LET'S TOGETHER MAKE MUMBAI MALARIA FREE Ex.Eng.(SWM)Planning

DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL- I, KOLKATA
PUBLIC NOTICE FOR SALE OF AIRCRAFT THROUGH E-AUCTION
IDBI BANK LTD VS M/S PATHBREAKING PROJECTS LIMITED (in liquidation)
(Formerly Abhijeet Projects Ltd.) & others OA no.124/2016

Receiver appointed by **DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL-I (DRT-I)**, Kolkata, invites offer through E-auction for purchase on "as is where is basis, as is what is basis, whatever there is basis and without any recourse basis", without any representation, warranty, or indemnity following aircraft of Pathbreaking Projects Limited.

PROPERTY DESCRIPTION	AIRCRAFT-Model-BOMBARDIER – CHALLENGER-605, Registration-VT MKJ, MSN-5848, Year of manufacture- 2010, Engine – General Electric APU- Honeywell, Manufacturer- Bombardier (presently grounded at Nagpur Airport, (Maharashtra)
Reserve Price & EMD amount	Reserve Price: US \$ 29,20,000 (equivalent INR at exchange rate on the day of the sale as provided by IDBI Bank) EMD: US \$ 2,92,000 (equivalent INR at exchange rate on the day of submission of EMD as provided by IDBI Bank)
Minimum Incremental Bid	US \$ 5000/- per bid
Date of Sale Notice	September 05, 2026
Date of Aircraft Inspection	September 18, 2026 (Friday) From 12 pm to 4 pm
Last date of submission of offer along with EMD	October 07, 2026 till 5 pm
Date of e-auction	October 08, 2026
Time of e-auction	1200 hrs. to 1400 hrs.(with unlimited extension of 5 minutes each as per IST)

1. The sale would be conducted on e-auction platform at **website: <https://www.bankelections.com>** through e-auction service provider **C1 India Pvt. Ltd.**

2. The interested parties may submit their unconditional and unqualified offer along with EMD and other required documents before the last date. On verification of documents and receipt of the EMD, the bidders shall receive user id/password for their valid email id (mandatory for e-auction) from the e-auction service provider for participating in e-auction.

3. Intending bidder may obtain terms and conditions of the sale process from Shri Basudeb Mukherjee, Advocate/Receiver(M)9830033082, (e-mail) basudebmukherjee66@yahoo.in Shri Durga Prasad Chanagati, Deputy General Manager (T) 022-6622635655 (M) 9282322552 (e-mail) durgaprasad_chanagati@idbi.co.in and Shri Samir Kumar, Manager (T) 022-662263631(M) 8340502262 (e-mail) senir.kumar@idbi.co.in any working day (except bank holidays) between 11.00 AM to 5.00 PM from September 05, 2026 to October 06, 2026. The same can also be downloaded from IDBI website (www.idbi.com) and from E-AUCTION provider website: <https://www.bankelections.com> (C1 India Pvt. Ltd).

4. Interested buyers may contract the above officials of the bank for inspection of the aircraft.

Place: Kolkata Receiver
Date: September 03, 2026 DRT-I, Kolkata

‘Ecommerce Exports to Help Small-town Businesses’

PTI

New Delhi: The government's measures to promote exports through e-commerce would give a major boost to the businesses of traders in small towns across the country, experts said on Friday. Products made by artisans involved in

sectors such as handlooms, handicrafts, and jewellery would be able to access global markets, they said.

"Ecommerce is allowing a seller in Karur, Panipat, Jaipur, Moradabad or Tiruppur to reach overseas buyers much earlier in its growth journey," Gaurav Shisodia, vice president and co-

untry manager, Payoneer India, said.

However, he said that discovering customers is only the first step and small exporters also need dependable cross-border payment infrastructure that can

पनवेल महानगरपालिका, पनवेल
ई- निविदा सूचना
मलनिःसारण विभाग

मा.आयुक्त, पनवेल महानगरपालिका यांच्या वतीने ई-निविदा प्रणालीद्वारे (ऑनलाईन) ब-१ नमुन्यातील खालील कामाची निविदा महाराष्ट्र शासनाकडील नोंदणीकृत संस्था, ठेकेदार, किंवा नोंदणीकृत कंपनी, भागीदारी कंपनी नोंदणीकृत LLP कायदा २००८ अंतर्गत संबंधितांकडून मागविण्यात आली आहे.

अ. क्र.	निविदा क्र.	कामाचे नाव	अंदाजपत्रकीय रक्कम (GST वगळून) रु.	निविदा अनामत रक्कम (रु.)	कोरी ई निविदा किंमत (रु.)
१	PMC/ SEWERAGE 01/2026-27	पनवेल महानगरपालिका मालकीच्या कामोटे, सेक्टर-३२ येथील ८५ द.ल.लि. क्षमतेचा मलप्रक्रिया (STP) केंद्राचे नूतनीकरण करून दोन वर्षांकरिता परिचलन, निगा, दुस्स्ती करणे. (2nd Call)	रु. ३९,२८,०४,१८७/- रु. ३५,१७,०३,५६०/- Biddable Amount* रु. ४,११,००,६२७/- Non Biddable Amount	रु. १९,६४,१००/-	रु. ३,५४०/-

या कामाच्या ई-निविदेबाबतची माहिती माहिती शासनाच्या <https://mahatenders.gov.in> या संकेतस्थळावर दिनांक ०७/०९/२०२६ रोजी प्रसिद्ध करण्यात येईल. संबंधित निविदाधारकांनी याची नोंद घ्यावी. सही/-
अतिरिक्त आयुक्त (I)
ज.क्र./पमपा/मल.वि./२२२५/प्र.क्र. ०२/८६६/२०२६ दिनांक : ०४/०९/२०२६ पनवेल महानगरपालिका

Government of Maharashtra
Office of Executive Engineer, Nashik Irrigation Division, Nashik
Address: Sinchan Bhavan, Trimbak road, Nashik
Email ID- eenidnashik@gmail.com Telephone No. 0253-2573192

E Tender Notice No.10 For 2026-2027
NOTICE INVITING E-TENDERS

RFP are invited from the persons owning or operating or having experience in Development of Hotels/Sites/Restaurants/Tent sites/Visitor Centre/Aquatic Tourism for Development of Gangapur Dam Tourism Project (Resort and Aquatic Tourism) under Design Build Finance Operate Transfer (DBFOT) Model on the following property on "As is where is basis" on Public Private Partnership Lease basis of 49 years at Gangapur Dam, Dist. Nashik, Maharashtra.

Sr. No.	Name of Property	Property Details	Present Value of Property (Rs in Lakh)	One time Premium (Non-refundable) (Rs in Lakh)	Minimum Avg. Yearly Bid Value (Rs in lakh)	EMD (Rs in Lakh)	Annual Turnover (Not less than) (Rs in Lakh)	Period Years
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1	Gangapur Dam,	Girnare Village Survey No. 321- Developable Area = 9.35 Ha Lat: 20°03'19.33" N Long: 73°39'54.18" E	1,178.10	22.09	14.73	5.89	883.58	49

E-Tender Available Period : Date 04/09/2026 To 24/09/2026
E-Tender Opening Date 25/09/2026

Sd/-
Executive Engineer
Nashik Irrigation Division
Nashik

DGIPR/2026-2027/2639

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
No. ECR/CAO/Con/WT/Tender/North/13-26-27, dated: 02.09.2026
(Construction Department)
E-TENDER NOTICE
No. ECR-CAO-C-N-13-26-27

E-TENDER IS INVITED ON BEHALF OF THE PRESIDENT OF INDIA FOR THE UNDERMENTIONED WORK:-

S.N. 1. Name of work with it's location: Particulars: Earthwork, Blanketing, Turfing in approach of Bridge No. 16 (UP & DN Line) and transportation, launching & erection of 1x30.5m+3x61m+1x30.5m OWG girder and other Miscellaneous work in connection to Rebuilding of Bridge No. 16 between Khagaria-Umeshnagar of Sonpur Division,

2. Approx. cost of the work of: Rs. 34,59,61,540.66, **3. Bid Security Amount:** Rs. 69,19,200.00, **4. Date and time for closing of tender :** 29.09.2026 at 14.30 hrs., **6. Website particular, Notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and addressed of the office from where the tender form be purchased etc:** The above E-Tender, E-Tendering document alongwith full information is available on website i.e. <http://www.ireps.gov.in>.

Note: In case of any discrepancies found in tender notice, English version will be final. Tenderers are requested to visit the website <http://www.ireps.gov.in> at least 15 days before last date of closing, for latest corrigendum/corrections etc in response to this E-tender.

CAO/Con/North
EC Rly. MHX, Patna
PR/0865/CN/N/MHX/CONST/IT/26-27/48

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
CORRIGENDUM
Corrigendum Notice No. W.584/E-Tendering/174, 175, 189, 190-DHN-26-27 Dhanbad, dt.03.09.2026.

It is further to notify the, Date and Time of closing of e-tender No. 174-DHN-2026-27, 175-DHN-2026-27, 189-DHN-2026-27 and 190-DHN-2026-27 dtd. 27.08.2026 should be read as closing at 13:00 hours on 21.09.2026 instead of at 12:00 hours on 21.09.2026.

All other details, term and condition exists in the e-tender notice No. 174-DHN-2026-27, 175-DHN-2026-27, 189-DHN-2026-27 and 190-DHN-2026-27 dtd. 27.08.2026 will remain unchanged and unaltered.

Divl. Railway Manager (Engg.)/ ECR/Dhanbad
PR/0873/DHN/Engg./C/26-27/24

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY
E-TENDER
CPM/GSU/NWR Ajmer on behalf of The President of India invites E-Tenders for the following work up to 15.00 Hrs. on the mentioned date. **Tender No:** SNT-GSU-AII-2026-27-04; **Name of work:** S&T work in Connection with -" Daurai Conversion of platform no. 2 into island platform at Daurai station and extension of it towards Saradhna end, of Ajmer Division of NWR; **Approximate cost of work:** Rs. 80,70,474.07/-; **Bid Security:** Rs. 1,61,500.00/-; **Date & Time of closing E-Tender:** 25.09.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. **Date & Time of opening E-Tender:** 25.09.2026 at 15.30 Hrs. The details of above E-tender are available on website www.ireps.gov.in

1284-AM/26
Please join us on /NWRRailways

FORM A
PUBLIC ANNOUNCEMENT
(Under Regulation 6 of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (Insolvency Resolution Process for Corporate Persons) Regulations, 2016)

FOR THE ATTENTION OF THE CREDITORS OF INFILLOOM INDIA PRIVATE LIMITED

RELEVANT PARTICULARS

1. Name of corporate debtor	Infilloom India Private Limited
2. Date of incorporation of corporate debtor	06/10/1995
3. Authority under which corporate debtor is incorporated / registered	Roc – Pune
4. Corporate Identity No. of corporate debtor	U17118PN1995PTC018285
5. Address of the registered office and principal office (if any) of corporate debtor	Gat No. 1231 (Part), Sanaswadi, Taluka Shirur, District Pune, Maharashtra - 412208.
6. Insolvency commencement date in respect of corporate debtor	04/09/2026
7. Estimated date of closure of insolvency resolution process	03/03/2027
8. Name and registration number of the insolvency professional acting as interim resolution professional	Pulkit Gupta IBBI/PA-001/IP-P-02364/2021-2022/13697
9. Address and e-mail of the interim resolution professional, as registered with the Board	Address: EY Restructuring LLP, 3rd Floor Workmark 1, (IGI Airport Hospitality District, Aerocity, New Delhi - 110037 E-mail: pulkit.gupta@ey.com
10. Address and e-mail to be used for correspondence with the interim resolution professional	Address: EY Restructuring LLP, 14th Floor, The Ruby, 29 Senapati Bapat Marg, Dadar (West), Mumbai - 400028 Kindly ensure that all claims and claim-related queries are sent only to: E-mail: claims.iri@gmail.com For any other query please mail to: E-mail: insolvency.iri@gmail.com
11. Last date for submission of claims	18/09/2026
12. Classes of creditors, if any, under clause (b) of sub-section (6A) of section 21, ascertained by the interim resolution professional	Not Applicable
13. Names of Insolvency Professionals identified to act as Authorised Representative of creditors in a class (Three names for each class)	Not Applicable
14. (a) Relevant Forms and (b) Details of authorized representatives are available at	(a) Web link: https://ibbi.gov.in/home/downloads (b) Details of authorized representatives are available at

Notice is hereby given that the National Company Law Tribunal has ordered the commencement of a corporate insolvency resolution process of Infilloom India Private Limited on September 04, 2026. The creditors of Infilloom India Private Limited are hereby called upon to submit their claims with proof on or before September 18, 2026, to the interim resolution professional at the address mentioned against entry No. 10. The financial creditors shall submit their claims with proof by electronic means only to claims.iri@gmail.com. All other creditors may submit the claims with proof in person, by post or by electronic means.

Submission of false or misleading proofs of claim shall attract penalties. Sd/-
Pulkit Gupta
Interim Resolution Professional
Reg No: IBBI/PA-001/IP-P-02364/2021-2022/13697
Registered Address: EY Restructuring LLP, 3rd Floor Workmark 1, (IGI Airport Hospitality District, Aerocity, New Delhi - 110037
Correspondence Address: EY Restructuring LLP, 14th Floor, The Ruby, Place: Mumbai 29 Senapati Bapat Marg, Dadar (West), Mumbai - 400028

Date: September 05, 2026

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A TIMES INTERNET INITIATIVE

Manyavar Mohey

VEDANT FASHIONS
- LIMITED -
CIN: L51311WB2002PLC094677

Regd. Office: Paridhan Garment Park, 19 Canal South Road
SDF-1, 4th Floor, A501-A502, Kolkata 700015, WB, India
Tel No.: (033) 6125 5495, Email: complianceofficer@manyavar.com
Website: www.vedantfashions.com

NOTICE OF THE 24TH ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING OF VEDANT FASHIONS LIMITED TO BE HELD THROUGH VIDEO CONFERENCING / OTHER AUDIO-VISUAL MEANS

Notice is hereby given that the 24th (Twenty-Fourth) Annual General Meeting ("the AGM" or "the Meeting") of the Members of Vedant Fashions Limited ("the Company") will be held on Monday, September 28, 2026 at 03.00 P.M. (IST) through Video Conferencing ("VC") or Other Audio-Visual Means ("OAVM") to transact the businesses as set out in the Notice convening the said AGM ("the Notice") in compliance with all the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013, ("the Act") read with the Rules issued thereunder, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, as amended ("Listing Regulations") read with General Circular No. 14/2020 dated 8th April, 2020, Circular No. 17/2020 dated 13th April, 2020, Circular No. 20/2020 dated 5th May, 2020, and subsequent circulars issued in this regard, the latest being General Circular No. 03/2025 dated 22nd September, 2025, issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") and other applicable Circulars issued in this regard by the MCA and the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI"). The deemed venue of the AGM shall be the Registered Office of the Company.

In compliance with the aforesaid Circulars read with Regulation 36 of the Listing Regulations, the Notice convening the AGM and the Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 ("FY 2025-26") have been sent electronically (i.e. through emails) on September 4, 2026 to all shareholders whose email addresses are registered with the Company and/or the Registrar and Share Transfer Agent ("the RTA") i.e., KFin Technologies Limited ("KFin" or "KFinTech") and/or Depository/ Depository Participant(s) ("DPs") and holding equity shares of the Company as on Friday, August 28, 2026. For Members whose e-mail addresses are not registered with the Company, RTA or the Depository/ Depository Participants, a letter containing the web-link - along with the exact navigation path - to access the Notice and complete Annual Report for the FY 2026 has been sent to their registered postal addresses.

Instructions for remote e-Voting and e-Voting during AGM:

1. Pursuant to Section 108 and other applicable provisions, if any, of the Act and Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, and other applicable provisions as amended from time to time, the Secretarial Standards on General Meetings issued by the Institute of Company Secretaries of India and Regulation 44 of the Listing Regulations and other applicable Circulars, the Company is pleased to provide e-Voting facilities through KFin to its Members to enable its Members to cast their vote by electronic means, in respect of the businesses to be transacted at the AGM. The manner and instructions to cast votes through remote e-Voting as well as through e-Voting system during the Meeting have been provided along with the Notice. The Company has engaged the services of KFin as the agency to provide e-voting facility.

2. Remote e-Voting details:

EVENT	10212
Out-off date for e-Voting	Monday, September 21, 2026
E-Voting Start Date and Time	Friday, September 25, 2026, from 9.00 a.m. (IST)
E-Voting End Date and Time	Sunday, September 27, 2026, till 5.00 p.m. (IST)
E-Voting website of KFinTech	https://evoting.kfintech.com

The remote e-Voting module shall not be allowed beyond the aforesaid date and time and shall be disabled by KFin for voting thereafter.

The facility for e-Voting will also be made available during the AGM of the Company and the members attending the meeting who have not cast their votes by remote e-Voting shall be able to vote at the AGM.

A person whose name is recorded in the Register of Members or in Register of Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories as on the cut-off date shall only be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-Voting as well as e-Voting during the AGM. Once vote(s) on Resolution(s) are cast by any Member, the same cannot be changed subsequently. A person who is not a member as on the cut-off date, should treat the Notice for information purpose only. The voting rights of the members shall be in proportion to their share in the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on the Cut-off date.

3. Any person who acquires equity shares of the Company and becomes a member after dispatch of the Notice and Annual Report and holds shares as on the cut-off date, i.e., Monday, September 21, 2026, may obtain the User Id and password for e-Voting, the detailed procedure is available in Notes to the Notice.

4. The instructions for remote e-Voting or e-Voting during the AGM for members holding shares in dematerialised form or physical form, and for members who have not registered their email addresses have been provided in the Notice. Instructions for attending AGM through VC/OAVM are also provided in the Notice.

5. Members who have exercised their voting rights by remote e-Voting prior to the AGM can participate in the AGM but shall not be entitled to cast their votes again.

6. The Board of Directors of the Company has appointed Ms. Khushi Agarwal, Practising Company Secretary (Membership No. F9795; Certificate of Practice No. 28428), Partner of M/s M&A Associates, Company Secretaries, as the Scrutinizer for conducting voting process in a fair and transparent manner.

7. All documents referred to in the Notice & the Explanatory Statement thereto shall be made available for inspection by the Members of the Company, without payment of fees, up to and including the date of AGM. Members desirous of inspecting the documents referred to in the Notice & the Explanatory Statement from their registered e-mail addresses mentioning their names and demat account numbers.

8. In case of any query and/or assistance required, relating to attending the Meeting through VC/OAVM mode, members may refer to the Help and Frequently Asked Questions and AGM VC/OAVM user manual available at the download Section of <https://evoting.kfintech.com> or on KFin's toll free No.: 1-800-309-4001 for any further clarifications/technical assistance that may be required. The grievances can also be addressed to the Company Secretary & Compliance Officer of the Company by sending an e-mail to complianceofficer@manyavar.com.

The Notice convening the 24th AGM and the Annual Report of the Company for the financial year ended March 31, 2026, are available on the website of the Company viz., www.vedantfashions.com and on the website of the Stock Exchanges where Equity Shares of the Company are listed, viz., www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com. The Notice shall also be available on the e-Voting website of the agency engaged for providing e-Voting facility, i.e., KFin, viz., <https://evoting.kfintech.com>.

The record date for the purpose of determining entitlement for the final dividend for FY 2025-26 is Monday, September 21, 2026. The final dividend, if approved by the Members at the AGM, will be paid, subject to deduction of tax at source, within the statutory period commencing from Tuesday, September 29, 2026. Pursuant to the SEBI Listing Regulations (Fifth Amendment), 2025, notified vide Notification No. SEBI/LAD-NRO/GN/2025/273 dated November 18, 2025 and effective from November 19, 2025, the final dividend shall be made in electronic mode only and no payable at par warrants or cheques or drafts shall be issued towards dividend payment. Where the dividend cannot be credited through electronic mode due to incomplete or incorrect bank account or KYC details, the dividend shall remain unpaid and shall be dealt with in accordance with the applicable provisions of the Act. Members are requested to update their bank account and KYC details with their respective DPs or the RTA, as applicable.

For Vedant Fashions Limited
Sd/-
Navin Pareek
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

Place: Kolkata
Date: September 5, 2026

Place: Kolkata Receiver
Date: September 03, 2026 DRT-I, Kolkata

VIA GOVT AUCTION

Shalimar Buys Lucknow Land Parcel for Record ₹450 cr

Faizan Haider

New Delhi: Lucknow based real estate developers Shalimar Corp has acquired an around 3-acre land parcel for ₹450 crore in the costliest deal of the city and among the costliest in tier 2 cities. Developers in tier 2 cities, especially in the capital city, are bullish on acquisition at prime locations with demand for premium housing growing. In total, 111 land deals spanning around 3,000 acres were inked in FY26, of which 520 acres were acquired in tier 2 cities. “The time has come for India’s Tier-2 cities to experience another wave of growth in real estate, aided by improved infrastructure, more industries and businesses, as well as homeowners’ ambitions. Consumers in this market segment are no longer interested only in affordable housing; they now want to live in planned neighbourhoods where they will find quality building, modern amenities, sustainability, and future appreciation,” said Khalid Masood, MD of Shalimar Corp. The firm has acquired the land through government auction and said that it was one of the last land parcels at a prime location in Lucknow.

Telco Operators Reject Quality of Service Norms for 5G Slicing

Call for resource utilisation benchmarks to be dropped while advocacy groups want them retained

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Telecom operators such as Reliance Jio, Bharti Airtel, and Vodafone Idea jointly pushed back against the telecom regulator’s draft proposals on quality of service (QoS) norms for commercial 5G network slicing, calling for the proposed resource utilisation benchmarks to be dropped entirely even as public advocacy groups said they can be retained.

In August, the telecom regulatory authority of India (Trai) released draft guidelines for telcos to deploy 5G network slicing-based use-cases to ensure that the dynamic resource allocation technology does not degrade service quality for general subscribers, amidst a debate around net neutrality.

Trai had proposed measuring quality of service by monitoring use of telecom resources in areas where slicing is activated, proposing that radio resources can’t exceed 80% utilisation to ensure there is breathing room when telcos divide the physical resource blocks to deliver specialised services.

Telcos opposed the move entirely, arguing that physical resource blocks utilisation is an internal radio-resource and input indicator, rather than a customer-facing quality of service metric. Actual customer

impact is being captured via metrics such as speed and throughput.

In its written comments as part of the stakeholder consultation by the Trai, Bharti Airtel said higher PRB utilisation does not mean poor QoS and setting an arbitrary 80% utilisation ceiling penalises operators for efficiently using scarce spectrum resources. Airtel added that imposing a rigid cell-level threshold will create artificial network constraints on operators, forcing them to prematurely augment capacity and misallocate capital expenditure on cells that are already delivering satisfactory throughput.

Reliance Jio added that the 80%

threshold as a mandatory trigger to suspend network slices is operationally unfeasible. Jio said modern 5G networks employ technologies specifically designed to trigger at high utilisation levels to ensure efficient spectrum utilisation.

Jio also argued that restricting utilisation levels ties auctioned spectrum to a specific service category, violating spectrum assignment conditions, technology neutrality, and ease of doing business. However, public policy think tanks such as The Dialog agreed with Trai that the proposal of measuring QoS through capacity

utilisation levels benchmark acts as a vital capacity safeguard to prevent slices from degrading the network. However, Trai should also use other means to measure impact.

GSMA argued that PRB utilisation is a useful internal planning indicator, but it should not be used in isolation as a regulatory measure of congestion or QoS. It said high utilisation during a cell’s busiest hour does not prove that users are experiencing poor service, or whether a particular slice caused the load, or immediate capacity augmentation is justified.

Vi opposed imposing such thresholds on cell-level, adding slicing as a tool is meant to be used when resources are constrained. When spare capacity is available, all users access the network at the highest possible throughput, linking slices to a utilisation threshold is technically unjustified.

At Crossroads		
ISSUE	TELECOM OPERATORS	THINK-TANKS/PUBLIC GROUPS
80% utilisation cap	Drop it as arbitrary and impractical	Retain it as a network safeguard
PRB* utilisation	Internal indicator, not customer-facing QoS	Useful for monitoring network capacity
High utilisation	Does not necessarily mean poor service	Could signal risks to overall network quality
Operational impact	May restrict spectrum use and increase costs	Provides essential capacity headroom
Network slicing	Threshold-based suspension is technically unworkable	Supports safeguards against service degradation
Speed benchmarks	Minimum speeds cannot be guaranteed wirelessly	Supports minimum speed benchmarks

IN RELIEF TO HARDWARE MANUFACTURERS...

Govt Floats Fresh IT Tenders at Higher Prices

Subhrojit Mallick

New Delhi: Government departments are adjusting to high prices of IT hardware by floating fresh tenders with 30-40% higher pricing, or procuring fewer units within the same pre-allocated budget.

This comes as a relief to manufacturers after some tenders lapsed, with no brands bidding at outdated prices.

Industry executives said many previous state government tenders floated earlier this year at outdated pricing were not finalised as no brands were ready to bid at those prices. For instance, orders placed by state governments of Chhattisgarh and Jharkhand for their respective state police forces were scuttled and as of now,

no fresh tenders have been floated yet for these projects.

Others such as the Tamil Nadu government have placed fresh orders of 30,000-40,000 desktop PCs at updated prices by floating a fresh tender in the June quarter, after scrapping older tenders. Government departments in Gujarat and Uttar Pradesh have also floated fresh tenders reflecting higher prices, executives said.

Acer, one of the largest suppliers to the government, said it has won a ₹2,200 crore deal from the Uttar Pradesh Government to supply 1.25 million 8-inch tablet PCs to students in Uttar Pradesh. Homegrown handset brand Lava International has also won a part of that tender, supplying 25 lakh tablets to students in the state ahead of assembly elections next year, the company confirmed.



some companies also cancelled orders being unable to fulfil government orders at outdated prices and had to forfeit their earnest money deposit and pay additional penalties, leading the government to issue fresh orders with updated pricing.

“Government bids are strict, highly detailed legal agreements that heavily favour the buyer. If a bidder defaults on an awarded tender, they face strict penalties, most notably forfeiting their earnest money deposit, which is around 10% of the total cost bid,” the executive added.

For brands, losing the deposit is still more profitable than supplying products at older prices, he said.

Acer’s Goel said that government tenders that were legally awarded and finalised before component prices surged, there was no room to negotiate.

In a Nutshell

Zaveri Group's Bid for GHPSL Set Aside by NCLAT

NEW DELHI The insolvency appellate tribunal NCLAT has set aside Zaveri Group’s resolution plan for Gujarat Hydrocarbons and Power SEZ (GHPSL) and directed the Resolution Professional and NCLT to start the process again by inviting fresh bids. A two-member NCLAT bench observed that the bid submitted by Zaveri & Co was based on an “unverified and contested presumption” that the leasehold of the land owned by the Gujarat Hydrocarbons and Power SEZ (GHPSL) will be de-notified from Special Economic Zone (SEZ) status.

Heavy Rains Hit Flight Ops at Delhi Airport

NEW DELHI At least 11 flights were diverted at the Delhi airport on Friday due to bad weather conditions. An official said 5 flights were diverted to Jaipur, 4 flights to Lucknow, and 1 flight each to to Ahmedabad and Chandigarh. The diversions happened between 3.30 pm and 5 pm, the official added. Heavy rains lashed various parts of the national capital on Friday afternoon. More than 400 flights were delayed at the Delhi airport on Friday, according to information available on flight tracking website Flightradar24.com.

Honasa Eyes 2-fold Rise in Revenue by FY31

NEW DELHI Honasa Consumer, the owner of beauty brand Mamaearth, expects a two-fold rise in its revenue to ₹5,550 crore in the next five years by FY31, said its founders on Friday. The company is also hopeful of its Ebitda margin expanding to 15% during the same period.

HUL Bets on Cost Cuts, Brand Push to Revive its Growth: MD

Co to raise capex, position some of its established brands around changing consumer trends: Execs

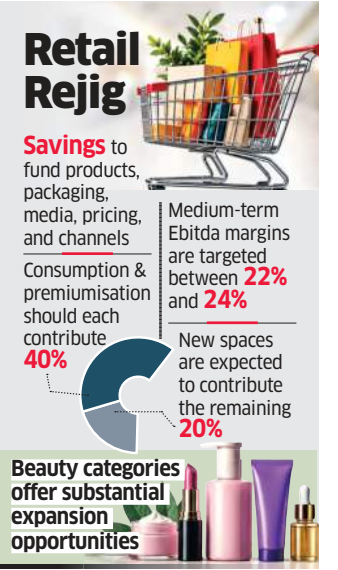
Aanya Thakur

Mumbai: Hindustan Unilever is looking to revive growth after a muted two-year period marked by cutting costs, sharpening portfolio and putting more money behind brands, distribution and new categories, managing director and chief executive Priya Nair said.

The country’s largest consumer goods company also plans to increase capital expenditure to 3% of turnover from 2%, with more than 75% of that directed towards growth and savings, Nair said at the company’s Capital Markets Day event.

HUL is targeting 500 basis points (5.0 percentage points) of “fuel for growth”, through a combination of improved margins, operating efficiencies and savings, chief financial officer Niranjana Gupta said. It plans to redeploy those gains into the business, including product and packaging, media and sampling, pricing and pack architecture and channel investments.

The maker of Rin and Dove has



set itself a medium-term Ebitda margin target of 22-24%. For FY26, the company posted an Ebitda margin of 23.6%.

The plan is to generate savings without relying on cost cuts alone, with HUL also seeking to increase operating leverage as revenue growth outpaces expansion in fixed costs.

Nair’s strategy is built around four growth pools—increasing consumption, premiumisation, bringing

more consumers into categories and entering new spaces. HUL expects consumption and premiumisation to each account for 40% of incremental turnover, with new spaces contributing 20%, Nair told investors. The company, often considered a proxy for consumer demand in India, is also betting on a shift in consumer preferences within its existing portfolio.

In beauty and wellbeing, HUL sees substantial room to expand categories such as bodywash, skin cleansing and functional deodorants, executive director Harman Dhillion said. The company plans to invest in developing functional deodorants, citing low usage in India and changing lifestyles as an opportunity.

HUL is also putting more resources behind premium beauty. More than 60% of its media spending is digital, while investment in premium brands is twice that of non-premium brands.

Foods executive director Rajneet Kohli said the business is looking to reposition some of its established brands around changing consumption trends. Horlicks, for instance, is being pushed toward lifestyle nutrition, with a focus on superfoods and protein. The broader foods strategy also includes premiumisation, functional nutrition, convenience and ready-to-drink beverages.

Stellantis in Talks with Huawei, JAC over Maserati Deal

Reuters

Milan: Automaker Stellantis is in talks with China’s Huawei and JAC Group for long term industrial cooperation on its struggling luxury brand Maserati, two sources told Reuters. Stellantis CEO Antonio Fiolosa said earlier this year that the world’s fourth-largest automaker was working on further manufacturing partnerships, including for Maserati, after such deals emerged as a key pillar of the group’s new long-term strategy.

A new deal for Maserati will have a positive impact on production rates at the Cassino and Modena plants in Italy, where the brand’s models are manufactured, he said.

Italian daily Milano Fiananza first reported on Friday about ongoing talks between Stellantis, Huawei and JAC Group over Maserati.

The luxury brand - which shipped fewer than 8,000 cars last year, posting an adjusted operating loss of €198 million (\$230 million) — is due to present its own long term strategy in December.

A spokesperson for Stellantis said that, as part of its normal course of business, the company holds discussions with a range of industry players around the world on various topics, “always with the ultimate aim of providing customers with the best mobility choices”.

Rio to Take a Leaf out of Gujarat’s ‘Green’ Playbook

Country to adopt Gujarat’s emissions trading model, recognised by Earthshot Prize, to deal with air pollution problem

Urmi Goswami

New Delhi: Gujarat’s success in bending the industrial pollution curve through the creation and implementation of a particulate emissions market is a case study worth examining. Several states, including Maharashtra, have lined up to follow suit.

Actually, Gujarat’s pioneering emissions trading model has found a taker abroad. This June, at London Climate Week, Rio de Janeiro mayor Eduardo Cavaliere announced plans for the city to take a leaf out of Gujarat’s book and set up a market for pollutants.

The journey from Surat to Rio would not have been possible without collaboration and cooperation. It required academics, governments, industry, philanthropists and even royalty to come together to make it happen.

The blueprint for emissions trading was established in the US through the SO2 programme to tackle acid rain. That plan was refined and scaled up into the EU’s Emissions Trading System (ETS) to reduce greenhouse gas emissions. The cap-and-trade approach worked in developed industrialised economies. But it had never been tried in a developing country where pollution is a major health, environmental and economic challenge.

In 2010, the environment and forests ministry invited academics, including current University of Chicago professor Michael Greenstone, from Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL) to design a mechanism to tackle particulate matter pollution. Designing the system was

the easy part. Ensuring data integrity proved more difficult. It was only in 2019 that Surat was ready to test the market for real.

The Surat emissions market is a milestone in environmental policy, demonstrating that market-linked systems to curb pollution can succeed in rapidly developing economies. From low compliance with emissions norms, the industrial hub achieved 99% compliance.

Participating industrial units in Surat have collectively reduced particulate matter emissions by roughly a

third compared with conventional factory clusters. The cost of controlling pollution also fell thanks to the trading system.

The Surat experiment demonstrated that developing countries do not need to sacrifice economic growth for clean air. This achievement caught the attention of the Earthshot Prize, an award launched by Britain’s Prince William in 2020 to identify and support solutions that “repair the planet”. Its successful use of market mechanisms to control pollution resulted in Gujarat being shortlisted as one of the finalists for the 2025 Earthshot Prize.

Rio mayor Cavaliere will now adopt market-based solutions to air pollution in South America for the first time. Gujarat’s emissions trading scheme, recognised by the Earthshot Prize, proves cities can harness innovative tools to protect people and the future.

GPT-6 outperformed several rival models on coding, cybersecurity and more, claims co

Astra May Tilt the Balance in Favour of OpenAI, Again

Super Weapon

Trained on 100,000 GPUs at “\$18, it’s one of the costliest models

Advanced capabilities in fin modelling, chip design, 3D modelling, reasoning, gaming

BALANCE OF POWER

Projected IPO Valuations \$2T OpenAI \$3T Anthropic

PIPS ALL AI MODEL SERIES

Anthropic: Fable, Mythos, Opus

Google: Gemini

Meta: Muse Spark

SpaceXAI: Grok

Alibaba: Qwen

Moonshot: Kimi

Himanshi Lohchab

Mumbai: OpenAI’s latest GPT-6 Astra appears to have raised the bar in the frontier AI model race with its ability to perform complex, multi-step knowledge work on its own across financial modelling, chip design, geospatial mapping, 3D modelling, architecture and software engineering.

Unveiled on Thursday, Astra has outperformed rival models from Anthropic, Google, Meta and Chinese labs Alibaba and Moonshot on key benchmarks for coding, cybersecurity, computer use and reasoning, according to the Sam Altman-led company.

“Anything you can do on a computer, Astra can do for you. Fast,” OpenAI said in its launch video, which demoed the model designing a rocket, creating an eBay listing, building a 3D game, editing a licensing agreement and ordering food—all through simple voice commands. Some see it as another “ChatGPT moment” for OpenAI.

Astra would potentially allow companies to delegate complicated tasks to AI agents, even without any human interference.

“GenAI is moving towards long horizon autonomous work,” said Gaurav Sharma, founder and CEO of SaaS Labs, a Bengaluru-based business process automation startup. “Astra sees a new environment, infer rules and figures out what to do. Along with solid browser use capabilities, it opens up so many automation opportunities.”

OpenAI president Greg Brockman called Astra “the moment AGI arrived.”

Artificial general intelligence (AGI) is loosely defined as the stage when AI can perform any intellectual task at or above human level.

Astra has saturated ARC-AGI, one of the world’s toughest benchmarks for measuring AGI by scoring 99.9%, according to OpenAI. Claude Opus’ score was 30.2%.

However, this claim was widely contested on social media and the internet, with many noting that Astra achieved 62.7% on the standard harness—the benchmark used for other models.

High capability also means high risk. In fact, because of its advanced cyber capabilities, Astra is currently available only in private preview to a handful of American firms including Palo Alto Networks, CrowdStrike, Cisco and Cloudflare—a rollout strategy similar to Anthropic’s restricted release of Mythos.

Vinayak Godse, chief executive of Data Security Council of India (DSCI), said the industry lacks benchmarks sophisticated enough to evaluate what latest AI models can actually do. Organisations will need new ways to test, govern and safely deploy AI systems with advanced cyber capabilities, he said.

DSCI is part of software industry grouping Nasscom.

Many entrepreneurs are waiting to get their hands on the latest GPT model.

For Mumbai-based geospatial mapping company Genesys International, Astra could help transform digital twins from passive 3D maps into AI-powered systems that can investigate problems, run simulations, predict outcomes and recommend actions with minimal human intervention, its chairman and managing director Sajid Malik said.

Vinay Agastya, founder of 3D-modelling startup Ctruh, said Astra’s advances in 3D image and video generation validate the growing importance of spatial computing and could make creating immersive digital experiences faster and more accessible across industries.

PREPARING TO RESPOND TO MKT TREND: EXEC

Kia Looks to Roll Out Multiple Powertrains to Meet India Demand

Shally Seth Mohile & Sharmistha Mukherjee

New Delhi: Kia India is preparing to simultaneously introduce electric vehicles, hybrids and CNG models, underscoring its struggle to predict which powertrain will emerge as the dominant choice in the world’s third-largest automobile market, a strategy its India chief said is placing a “huge burden” on carmakers. “Electrification is the main wave,” Gwang-gu Lee, managing director at Kia India told ET. “I don’t have any doubt on that. But only the timing, the speed, something like that. We should be prepared to respond to real market trend.”

Unlike Europe, where EVs have rapidly attained prominence, or the US where hybrids have gained greater traction, India is seeing demand develop across powertrains, Lee said. Strong sales of CNG cars, which Kia hadn’t anticipated, highlights how quickly customer preferences can shift in India.

“It is a huge burden on the OEM (original equipment manufacturers), but we have to do that,” said Lee. “Hybrid is one of the options, and we have to do that. And then electric, and even CNG.”

Lee was speaking on the sidelines of the introduction of Sorento, Kia India’s first three-row SUV which can seat up to seven. The SUV will be available in hybrid petrol variant in addition to diesel. With prices ranging from ₹27.99 lakh to ₹40.4 lakh—depending on the range and powertrain, Sorento will rival the Toyota Fortuner, Volkswagen Tayron, and Skoda Kodiaq, among others.

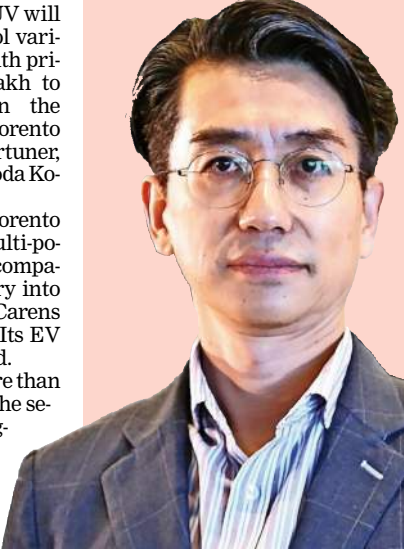
The introduction of the Sorento marks the start of Kia’s multi-powertrain strategy, with the company also announcing its entry into the CNG market with the Carens and Carens Clavis models. Its EV portfolio is also set to expand.

CNG now accounts for more than 20% of cars sold in India—the second-largest powertrain segment. Kia also plans to introduce a hybrid version of the Seltos in 2027, while it showcased a hybrid version of the Carnival mini-

KEEPING BUSY

India has never made me go to sleep, go to bed. India is so dynamic

GWANGGU LEE
MD, Kia India



DeepSeek Plans Big Huawei AI Chip Order to Power New Data Centre

Bloomberg

DeepSeek plans to deploy at least 160,000 of Huawei Technologies's top accelerators at a massive data centre it's building in Inner Mongolia, which could create one of the largest known clusters of Huawei AI chips and advance China's efforts to replace Nvidia.

The AI pioneer intends to use Huawei's next-generation Ascend 950DT chips for operating its models, though the timeline for installation will depend on Huawei's production capabilities, according to people familiar with the matter. The startup doesn't currently plan to use the 950DT chips for training, one of the people said, even though Huawei designed and marketed these processors to serve that more demanding function. While DeepSeek tried to train in its previous models on Huawei chips, it has so far relied on Nvidia

GOING FORWARD



Co intends to use Huawei's next-generation Ascend 950DT chips for operating its models

accelerators for this crucial step.

DeepSeek wants to purchase more of Huawei's best chips, according to the people, but China's semiconductor champion doesn't currently have the production capacity. Shortages of components such as top-end memory will cap Huawei's output of the 950DT at the low hundreds-of-thousands this year, one of the people said. Huawei is balancing demand from other clients and trying to export small volumes overseas, so fulfilling DeepSeek's order could take more than a year, the people said, speaking on condition of anonymity to discuss a confidential deal.

If completed as envisioned, the Inner Mongolia hub will be key to driving AI development at DeepSeek, which is in talks to raise billions of dollars to build out its infrastructure. The installation would dwarf other publicly known clusters of Huawei's Ascend processors, a meaningful step as China tries to wean itself off Nvidia components. By the time it comes online, according to one person with knowledge of Huawei's production capabilities, China could have several clusters of that size.

DeepSeek did not respond to requests for comment.

POST-MONEY IPO VALUATION UP 5X FROM LAST PRIVATE ROUND

Rentomojo Set to Go Public at ₹4,246 crore Valuation

Rental startup plans to raise ₹1,256 crore through a fresh issue and offer for sale

Disha Acharya & Tanishka Dubey

Bengaluru | Mumbai: Furniture and home electronics rental startup Rentomojo is seeking a valuation of about ₹4,246 crore as it prepares to launch its initial public offering (IPO) next week. The valuation is based on the upper end of the ₹384-404 per share price band it announced last week and is nearly five times higher than its ₹850-900 crore valuation from a private funding round in 2024.

The Bengaluru-based company is raising ₹150 crore in fresh capital, while its investors, including Accel, Chiratae Ventures and ValueQuest, are selling shares worth ₹1,106 crore under offer for sale (OFS). This brings the total issue size to about ₹1,256 crore.

Rentomojo's IPO will open for subscription on September 9 and close on September 11.

Early investors in the company, including Accel and Chiratae Ventures, are sitting on significant paper gains of up to 8.6X and almost 5X after the furniture and

BACK IN ACTION			
Shareholder / Investor	Current stake worth (₹ crore)*	OFS proceeds (₹ crore)*	Return on investment
Geetansh Bamania*	602	34	NA
Accel	857	317	8.6x
Edelweiss	431	116	5.4x
Chiratae Ventures	204	194	4.9x
ValueQuest	365	109	5.3x
Madison India Capital	272	97	7.2x

Note: *Founder | *At ₹404 per share Source: Rentomojo RHP

appliances rental platform set the upper end of its price band at ₹404 per share for its upcoming IPO.

Paper gains refer to unrealised capital gains existing shareholders hold before they sell their

stake to the public after the company is listed.

As part of OFS, Accel could make up to ₹317 crore and Chiratae Ventures could make up to ₹197 crore. Other investors, such as Madison India Capital, could ma-

ke 7.2X returns, or ₹97 crore.

At the upper end of the price band, Rentomojo's founder and promoter, Geetansh Bamania, holds a 14.7% stake in the company worth ₹602 crore. He is selling up to 849,175 shares, or about a 0.8% stake, and is expected to realise roughly ₹34 crore from the OFS.

"The business is now in its fourth year of profitability. We don't need to raise large amounts of primary capital," he said, adding that key shareholders including Accel, Edelweiss, Chiratae and ValueQuest will continue to own meaningful stakes after the IPO.

FY26 EARNINGS

In FY26, Rentomojo's net profit surged nearly 142% to ₹104.3 crore, up from ₹43 crore in the previous fiscal, largely on account of a one-time deferred tax credit of ₹36.6 crore in the previous fiscal year. Its operating revenue grew 45.5% to ₹387 crore in FY26 from ₹266 crore in FY25, driven by addition of new subscribers. Including other income of ₹7 crore, the company's total income for FY26 stood at ₹394 crore.

Smart Ring Maker Oura Files for US IPO as Revenue Surges

Bloomberg

Health and fitness ring-maker Oura filed for an initial public offering, showing soaring revenue as well as increasing losses.

The maker of smart rings that track health, fitness and sleep had a net loss attributable to stockholders of \$924.3 million on revenue of \$1.21 billion for the nine months ended June 30, compared with a net loss of \$687.6 million on revenue of \$897.6 million in the corresponding period a year earlier, according to its filing on Thursday with the US Securities and Exchange Commission. The losses include the effect of a deemed dividend to certain holders of redeemable convertible preferred stock, the filing shows.

Anthropic Finalising \$15b Pre-IPO Credit Facility

Claude maker eyes a blockbuster IPO that could rival SpaceX's debut

Bloomberg

Anthropic is set to finalise expanding its revolving credit facility to \$15 billion, according to people familiar with the matter, clearing a hurdle before the artificial intelligence firm's public filing for its highly anticipated IPO.

Morgan Stanley is leading the process, the people said. Goldman Sachs Group and JPMorgan Chase & Co also have prominent roles on the facility, along with Citigroup, they said. The four lenders are also leading the IPO, Bloomberg News has reported.

The Claude chatbot maker is seeking to raise as much as SpaceX or more in the initial public offering, people familiar with the



and UBS Group AG are also high in the credit facility's lineup, they said.

Generally, in syndicated loans, the higher the commitment of a bank, the higher the fees it gets paid by a borrower. When a large capital markets transaction is expected, a higher ranking in a loan is likely to correspond to a more active role in the upcoming deal.

Bank of Montreal, BNP Paribas SA, Credit Agricole SA, Mizuho Financial Group, Mitsubishi UFJ Financial Group, Sumitomo Mitsui Financial Group and Toronto-Dominion Bank are also on the so-called revolver, the people said.

The credit facility would exceed the company's roughly \$10 billion target, Bloomberg News reported in August.

preparations have said. Companies typically finalise the revolver before they notify banks of their formal roles in a listing.

Barclays and Wells Fargo & Co. are also expected to have key roles on the loan, the people said. Bank of America, Deutsche Bank AG, Royal Bank of Canada,

Forex Reserves up \$73.87b in Nine Weeks

From Page 1

The central bank sold \$7.7 billion in the spot market in August through large public sector banks to support the local currency, while it did not buy dollars. It sold a net of \$2.54 billion in July.

Forex reserves, which provides a critical buffer for imports, surged \$73.87 billion in the past nine weeks as overseas Indians responded positively to the foreign currency non-resident bank (FCNR-B) deposit mobilisation.

According to provisional data published by the central bank a couple of days ago, the country saw inflows over \$136.38 billion through the special programmes underpinned by a swap facility. Banks garnered \$127.226 billion through the FCNR-B window alone.

The FCNR-B scheme closed on

August 31, while other special borrowing programmes will continue until December 31. The central bank unveiled programmes involving a concessional dollar-rupee swap facility with itself on June 5 to prevent the rupee's fast depreciation in the backdrop of unabated dollar outflows, as overseas investors were offloading local financial assets in favour of safe-haven investments denominated in dollars.

Market participants said that the central bank was seen intervening in the market Friday while war-related concerns and higher oil prices weakened the other Asian currencies. Oil prices hovered around \$96 a barrel, rising about 7.4% in the week, as the Iran-US situation remained on the boil.



Curbs with Benefits

From Page 1

In his ruling dated September 2, Maharashtra charity commissioner Amogh Kaloti empowered trustees of NRTT "to take appropriate steps, if it is found that late Ratan N Tata has bequeathed his shares equally to some other charitable institutions in breach of the conditions attached to the transfer of shares and the express undertaking by Naval H Tata that his children would transfer or bequeath the shares to their own relatives and not to a third party."

The cumulative value of the publicly traded holdings of Tata Sons alone exceed ₹12 lakh crore, making a 0.83% equity stake worth more than ₹1,00,000 crore. Public holdings are only a part of the Tata empire, which also owns a number of privately held companies, making a valuation of the group a complex exercise.

The charity commissioner's ruling, based on the submissions of documents by Tata Trusts of deliberations and transactions dating back to 1989, found that the sale of shares by NRTT to Naval Tata was on the condition that those shares would remain within the Tata family. These conditions were based on a legal opinion by eminent jurist Nani Palkhivala, who said three con-

ditions should be imposed to avoid the transaction from being challenged later.

"(a) Naval H Tata will not alienate the shares to any party during his lifetime. If he wants to dispose of the shares at any time, he will resell them to the Trust or to a person nominated by the Trust;

(b) Naval H Tata will not bequeath, by his Will, the shares to anyone other than his own wife and children. He will have no right to bequeath the shares to any other party;

(c) even when Naval H Tata bequeaths the shares to his own wife or children, it should be on condition that they would again transfer or bequeath the shares only to similar relatives of their own and not to a third party"

He also laid down the benefits of imposing these restrictions: "If the above conditions are imposed, the benefits would be as follows: (i) The price of the shares transferred cannot be questioned since the shares would not be unconditionally transferred; (ii) It would have the further advantage that some shares of Tata Sons Limited would remain in the Tata family. This would be a very laudable objective which would be taken into account by any court of law in the event of the transfer being challenged by any party." Executors to be approached

Isro Puts Advanced Earth-Observation Satellite Into Orbit

EOS-05 to provide near-real-time imagery for agriculture, disaster management & strategic needs

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: The Indian Space Research Organisation (Isro) on Friday successfully launched the 2,367kg EOS-05 Earth-observation satellite aboard the GSLV-F17 launch vehicle from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota at 2.55 am.

The satellite was injected into its planned sub-geosynchronous transfer orbit about 18 minutes after liftoff. It is expected to be raised to an altitude of around 36,000km, where it will operate in geostationary orbit and match the Earth's rotation.

EOS-05 is described as India's first dedicated geostationary Earth-observation satellite. It is designed to provide near-real-time, multi-band imagery for applications including agriculture, disaster management and strategic national requirements.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi described the launch as "yet another outstanding achievement by Isro." "The successful launch is a reflection of the innovation and growing capabilities that define India's space sector," he said.

"The growing partnership between Isro and Indian industry is adding new strength and scale to our space programme and expanding India's capabilities across the entire space ecosystem," Modi added.

Isro chairman V Narayanan said improvements in the GSLV's structural design and propulsion systems had enabled the vehicle to carry increasingly heavier payloads.

Project Director (Satellite) Imteyaz Ahamed described EOS-05 as a unique, one-of-a-kind satellite with multi-band capabilities. He said its configuration, payload and capabilities made it a complex spacecraft.

Mission director Thomas Kurien said EOS-05 had been uniquely configured for near-real-time imaging. He added that it was the hea-

NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister



The successful launch is a reflection of the innovation and growing capabilities that define India's space sector



Indian Space Research Organisation's GSLV-F17 rocket carrying EOS-05 satellite lifts off from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre, in Sriharikota on Friday. PTI

viest satellite launched by the GSLV into a geostationary transfer orbit or sub-GTO.

The mission carried the heaviest payload ever launched by a GSLV, exceeding 2,300kg. Narayanan said the satellite had been precisely injected into the required orbit, its solar panels had deployed successfully, and its systems were functioning normally.

Asked about the satellite's operational life, Narayanan said, "I am confident it will work for more than nine years."

Orbit-raising manoeuvres will subsequently place the satellite in its operational geostationary position.

"This mission is very important for our country because, for the first time, we are going to place an Earth observation satellite in geosynchronous orbit, which is essentially required for continuously monitoring India and its nearby places for Earth observation," Narayanan said.

"Actually, this financial year, we are targeting six more launches. And we are planning to have the navigation satellite launch, NVS-03. Then, of course, we all are working for the Gaganyaan uncrewed vehicle. That is also targeted this calendar year," he said. "Gaganyaan, as you are aware, is a technology-intensive mission. So, we have to do the human-rating of the vehicle, and then the development of the crew escape system, development of the mandrel control system. And till today, around 8,000 tests have been completed," he said.

'Bull Run on Beer'

From Page 1

"The first quarter of this fiscal, which is the peak season for beer, has been good for the industry. Beer sales have grown by over 17% nationally over the same period last year. July trends too are not different," said Vinod Giri of the Brewers Association of India, which represents United Breweries, AB InBev and Carlsberg.

"This has ridden mainly on favourable excise policy interventions encouraging milder alcoholic beverages in many states," Giri said.

Beer sales in Maharashtra and Karnataka have expanded 42% and 35%, respectively, he said. The strong growth comes even as the industry continues to face pressure on profitability.

Kartikeya Sharma, president of AB InBev India, said Maharashtra "started the bull run on beer" after the state increased taxes on spirits.

"Maharashtra grew about 40-45% last year, even year to date it's growing 40%," Sharma said.

Karnataka has since joined the trend, with beer growing more than 50% over the past three months, he said. "Karnataka jumped onto the bandwagon with probably the most pivotal policy written that I think in history books would be the time beer took off from an inflection point with this alcohol and bottle policy," Sharma said.

Sharma said stronger beer sales were spread across several markets, with Telangana also showing healthy growth after a significant decline last year. West Bengal, Ha-



ryana and Uttar Pradesh have been more subdued.

LAGER LOVERS

Brewers also pointed to unusually dry conditions in August as a factor supporting beer consumption.

"So now we just need to hold on to this momentum and it could be one of the better single year industry growth that the category has seen in a very long time," he said.

The pressure on spirits is particularly significant because India's alcohol market remains heavily skewed toward lower-priced products. The country has more than 1.4 billion people, but its drinking population is estimated at around 300 million, with nearly half consuming low-cost or unbranded liquor.

The mass-premium segment, once a key growth driver for whisky, rum and brandy, has come under pressure from rising costs and local competition.

For fiscal 2025, both spirits and beer volumes grew about 4%. The latest quarter, however, shows a widening gap between the two categories as consumers respond to relative prices and state excise policies.

"When you then look at IMFL value, whether you're talking about premium or value, mid prestige, upper prestige, lower prestige. I think that's where state by state the conversation changes because in some cases there are excise policy reforms or changes, and that could create a vacuum temporarily," said Neeraj Kumar, India managing director, Suntory.

Key Innovation Hub

From Page 1

India has emerged as a critical innovation hub for Adobe, with nearly a third of the US company's global innovation, including newer Firefly AI capabilities currently powered by teams based in the country, Adobe executives told ET in April. The company has around 8,000 employees in India.

Globally, it owns flagship products such as Photoshop, Illustrator, Premiere Pro and InDesign. The company has pivoted toward AI-led products even as the stock price has slipped since 2024 owing to mounting fears of AI disrupting the software business. Continued vulnerability from major tech changes led to the stock price reducing 23% and 20.6% in 2024 and 2025, respectively. In 2026, shares have fallen 18.6% till date even as



creatively being integrated into Microsoft 365 workflows, and Google's advanced AI models being integrated directly into Adobe's creative tools like Firefly, Photoshop, Adobe Express, and Premiere Pro. The company is also collaborating with OpenAI to test ads in ChatGPT besides introducing Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Express, and Acrobat Apps for ChatGPT to the platform's 800 million weekly users, Adobe executives have said.

AMERICAN FORCES IN WEST ASIA TURN OFF AD TRACKERS

Vance: I Wouldn't Call Iran Conflict a War...

...‘as phase of hostilities lasted about six weeks’

US Vice President JD Vance downplayed the scope of the conflict in Iran, saying he would not describe it as “a war” given major combat operations ended months ago — even after a brief resumption of military strikes earlier in the week.

“I wouldn’t call it a war,” Vance said Thursday during a press briefing at the White House. “Right now, there is no active shooting. I recognize there have been places where this has flared up” but the major phase of hostilities lasted about six weeks, Vance added.

The vice president spoke days after the US launched a fresh assault on Iran in response to attacks on oil tankers trying to pass through the Strait of Hormuz. That prompted the Islamic Republic to again target US bases across West Asia.

Eighteen US service members have died and hundreds more Americans have been wounded since the US and Israel started the conflict in late February, while estimates indicate more than 3,500 Iranians have been killed. As of July, the Pentagon put the cost of the war at about \$37.5 billion, and the Trump administration is seeking an additional \$67 billion in defence funding.

TURKISH BANK SANCTIONED

Meanwhile, the Trump administration announced on Friday that it had imposed sanctions on a Turkish financial institution—Golden Global Yatirim Bankasi Anonim Sirketi—as part of its latest effort to sever “critical financial lifelines” for the Iranian government.

The treasury department accu-



A HEAVY TOLL

Since the US and Israel started the conflict, more than 3,500 Iranians have been killed, according to estimates

sed the Turkish bank and its entities of being established to enable Iran’s efforts to transfer oil revenues from China to Turkey, where they could then be converted to cash and gold.

‘N’ REPORT TO UN

Meanwhile, the US, Britain, Fran-

ce and Germany would seek a resolution in the UN nuclear watchdog’s (International Atomic Energy Agency’s) board next week reporting Iran to the UN Security Council for the first time in 20 years, according to diplomats and the proposed text.

MILITARY SECURITY UPDATE

US military officials said earlier on Friday that they had disabled advertising trackers on a range of phones and computers, according to letters released by US Senator Ron Wyden and statements by other officials, a development that follows reports that commercially available location data had been used to target American forces in West Asia. **Agencies**

Clash Between Houthis & Saudi-backed Forces Kills 81

Clashes between Yemen’s Houthis and Saudi-backed government forces have killed 81, military and medical sources said on Friday, as the Iran-backed rebels push towards territory bordering a chokepoint in the strategic Red Sea. Fighting erupted on Thursday, after the Houthis launched a ground assault along with rocket and drone attacks near coastal areas, vying for control of the narrow Bab al-Mandab strait at the Red Sea’s southern entrance. The Houthis have repeatedly attacked Saudi ships in recent weeks in the Red Sea, which has emerged as an alternative route for oil exports after Iran all but halted shipments from the Gulf by blockading the Strait of Hormuz. The rebels are now trying to cement their hold over one of the world’s busiest shipping lanes, which they have disrupted with attacks on passing vessels since the Gaza war broke out in 2023. **AFP**

5 EU Nations agree on Model to Send Rejected Migrants to ‘Return Hubs’

Denmark and four other European Union countries agreed on Friday on a model for “return hubs” in non-EU nations and hope to begin sending migrants to the facilities as early as 2027, an official said Friday.

The announcement, made after a one-day meeting in Copenhagen, is the latest development in an effort by EU states to send people whose asylum requests have been rejected to third countries outside the bloc.

“We are moving forward toward what is actually a fundamental transformation of the common European migration and asylum system,” said Morten Bodskov, Denmark’s minister of immigration and integration.

He briefed reporters alongside counterparts from Germany, the Netherlands, Austria and Greece.

The five countries have been negotiating with governments mainly in Africa over potential sites, pioneering the initiative for the whole of the EU.

Bodskov rejected the idea that “return hubs” were a euphemism for detention and deportation centres and said the International Organisation for Migration and the UN Refugee Agency would monitor the centres. **AP**

‘REPAY AMERICAN DOLLARS SPENT ON UKRAINE AID’

No Fed Rate Cut, No Trade: Trump

Washington: US President Donald Trump on Friday said that unless the Federal Reserve cut interest rates, he would stop trading with countries with which the United States had a deficit.

“High interest rates put the USA at a very unfair disadvantage, and I won’t allow that to happen!” said Trump, who has repeatedly demanded that the Fed cut rates.

The Bureau of Labor Statistics on Friday reported stronger-than-expected job creation in August, prompting traders to boost bets on a hike later this month.

“We should have the LOWEST RATE of any country in the World ... LOWER THE RATE OR I’LL STOP TRADING WITH COUNTRIES WITH WHICH WE HAVE A DEFICIT,” Trump said in a Truth Social post.

ASKS EUROPE TO REPAY AID

Earlier on Thursday, Trump said that he will ask Europeans to repay the American aid provided to Ukraine under the administration of his predecessor Joe Biden.

Trump has long demanded that Europeans shoulder more of the cost of Western support for Ukraine in its war with Russia, which began more than four years ago.

“Hundreds of Billions of Dollars was given to Ukraine and NATO, free of charge, that Europe would have paid for—If they were only asked, but we will be asking for that money, though somewhat belatedly!” Trump wrote on his Truth Social platform late on Thursday.

The American president did not



specify which countries he believed should pay.

In his post, Trump also rejected reports that the US military was running low on munitions in its war against Iran.

“We have virtually unlimited amounts of Mid to High Grade Ammunition,” he wrote, adding that munitions are being produced at “levels never seen before.”

Trump said that US was building up stockpiles and preparing for contingencies, and temporarily suspended overseas arms sales. **Agencies**

162k Jobs Trump Gets August Boost Before Midterms

Employment rolls for July revised to 21k from the earlier 23k retrenchments

Washington: The US job market rebounded in August, according to a poll by FactSet. Labor Department revisions also looked good, adding 55,000 to June and July payrolls. Employers created 21,000 jobs in July; the department had originally reported that they had cut 23,000.

And the US labour force—the number of people working or looking for work—jumped by 683,000 last month after falling in June and July.

Companies have been contending with a shortage of workers—the result of President Donald Trump’s immigration crackdown and the retirement of baby boomers—and some are responding by using technology for tasks that human beings used to do. But employers have been reluctant to let go of the staff they have, so most Americans enjoy unusual job security and unemployment is low.

“It’s a very strange labor market,”



4.1% UNEMPLOYMENT RATE STILL LOW

sult of President Donald Trump’s immigration crackdown and the retirement of baby boomers—and some are responding by using technology for tasks that human beings used to do. But employers have been reluctant to let go of the staff they have, so most Americans enjoy unusual job security and unemployment is low.

David Kelly, chief global strategist at J.P. Morgan Asset Management, wrote in a commentary Monday. The No. 1 puzzler: Hiring is weak, but layoffs are rare.

Employers haven’t been eager to take on new workers.

The Labor Department reported Tuesday that gross hiring—before subtracting people who lost or left their jobs—fell 5% to fewer than 5.1 million new jobs.

The United States doesn’t need as many jobs as it did until recently to keep the national unemployment rate from rising. Trump’s immigra-

\$5.85 Diesel Prices Hit Another Homerun

Chicago: Diesel hit a new record price in the US on Friday, soaring to an average of \$5.85 a gallon for the first time ever as the six-month war with Iran disrupts the world’s flow of fuel. As diesel is used for many freight and delivery networks, higher diesel prices mean higher transportation costs for everyday goods. This could add to Republicans’ political ahead of November’s midterm elections. **AP**

tion crackdown and baby boomer retirements mean fewer people are competing for work.

More than 1.3 million people have dropped out of the US labour force over the past year.

As a result, the “break-even” rate of monthly hiring, 155,000 in 2023-2024, has dropped, perhaps to nearly zero, according to a Federal Reserve study. **AP**

‘Civilian Leader’ Telle is POTUS’ New Army Secy

Washington: President Donald Trump on Thursday named Adam Telle, a civilian leader in the US Army Corps of Engineers, as the acting Army secretary following the departure of Dan Driscoll amid widespread reports of tensions with defence secretary Pete Hegseth.



Telle is currently the assistant secretary of the Army for civil works. But he spent more than 20 years working for Republican senators as well as in the White House during Trump’s first term, serving as chief liaison to the Senate, according to an Army bio. **AP**

Musk ‘PACs’ a \$800k Punch for Nov Polls

Tesla CEO readies \$50 m war chest to help Republican candidates facing close fights

New York: Elon Musk has spent more than \$800,000 in recent days on over a dozen key congressional races through his super PAC, funding direct-mail and other campaign materials for Republican candidates who face close races in the midterm elections.

Musk’s political action committee America PAC, which has been sitting on a \$50 million war chest funded by the world’s richest man, reported its first spending for the 2026 election in a filing late on Wednesday, with a focus on races in Texas and other battleground sta-



tes.

The PAC expects to play a major role in Republican voter turnout efforts, with spending on door knockers, digital advertising and direct-mail campaigns ahead of the November 3 election. It has a funding target of up to \$120 million, according to NYT.

The PAC spent the most money in Texas, where Musk’s SpaceX is headquartered with multiple rocket

and Starlink facilities. Texas Attorney General Ken Paxton has received a \$247,595 boost from Musk since August 20 for his Senate race against Democrat James Talarico, who has been narrowly leading in public opinion polls since mid-April according to election tracker Nate Silver’s Silver Bulletin.

Senator Susan Collins, a Maine Republican and the chair of the Senate Appropriations Committee which controls federal spending, was the next biggest beneficiary with \$170,224 going towards her campaign, the filing shows. She is in a closely watched race against Democrat Troy Jackson.

In Ohio, where Republican Senator Jon Husted faces a tough battle against former Senator Sherrod Brown, America PAC has printed \$105,675 in materials. **Reuters**

Biz Buzz: Xi Plans to Bring Big CEO Team Along on US Visit

Move unusual given American scepticism towards investments from Chinese firms

Beijing: President Xi Jinping is preparing a large business delegation to accompany him on his visit to Washington, two sources said, an unusual move given US scepticism towards Chinese investment and Beijing’s strained ties with private enterprise.

Xi rarely travels abroad with corporate executives, many of whom fell out of favour after Beijing’s regulatory crackdowns on the technology, education and property sectors that began in 2020.

The planned business delegation for the September 24 summit has not been previously reported. Reuters could not determine which executives would join the delegation.

The move is aimed in part at signalling China’s willingness to support investment and commercial ties with the US, while offering the White House some potential economic wins ahead of midterm elections, one of the sources familiar with discussions said.

Chinese companies have faced increasing scrutiny of their US investments and business operations in recent years.

Washington has imposed a 100% tariff on imported Chinese EVs, banned foreign drone, router and robot imports, and forced the divestiture of TikTok’s US operations.

It also placed major Chinese tech firms on the Entity List of firms or organisations deemed a threat to national security and on a Pentagon blacklist.

Xi last brought a sizeable business contingent to the US in



2015, including Alibaba founder Jack Ma, Tencent founder Pony Ma, and executives from Chinese banks and state-owned firms. During that visit, China signed a \$38 billion agreement for 300 Boeing aircraft and Xi met

U.S. technology executives including Apple’s Tim Cook, Meta’s Mark Zuckerberg and Amazon founder Jeff Bezos.

RARE EARTHS A RARITY FOR US

Some Chinese rare earth supplies are declining to ship to the US for fear of repercussions from Beijing, three sources said, underscoring how access to the materials remains an issue for the US weeks before President Xi visits Washington.

US officials have repeatedly asked China to stick to commitments made in Busan and Beijing over the past year to ensure the smooth flow of rare earth export licences.

The persistence of the problem has put it on the US planning agenda ahead of Xi’s September 24 visit, a source familiar with the work said. **Reuters**

WARS AND WEATHER DISRUPTIONS TO BLAME

World Food Prices in Aug are Highest Since Late ‘22

Paris: World food prices rose in August to their highest since late 2022, as adverse weather and war disruption in the Black Sea heightened concern over supply of staples, the United Nations’ Food and Agriculture Organization said on Friday.

Extreme heat and drought in Europe, the threat of a severe El Nino weather pattern and trade upheaval caused by the Ukraine and Iran wars have unsettled agricultural markets, pushing grain prices to three-year highs and sugar to a one-year peak.



The FAO Food Price Index averaged 133.3 points in August, up from July’s revised reading of 130.8.

That was the highest score since November 2022, though nearly 17% below a record peak from March 2022, after Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

“August’s increase in global food prices is a warning that the risk premium is returning to food markets: climate shocks, geopolitical tensions and disrupted trade logistics are converging to tighten supply expectations,” FAO Chief Economist Maximino Torero said in a statement.

The FAO’s price benchmarks for cereals, vegetable oils, sugar, meat and dairy all rose in August.

The extreme weather in Europe affected prospects for the maize (corn) and sugar beet harvests as well as livestock output, while the anticipated El Nino phenomenon fuelled concerns for palm oil and sugar output in Asia, it said. **Reuters**

Bitcoin Reclaims Mt \$80k Despite Choppy Demand



Bitcoin is back above \$80,000. The question is whether it can stay there. The cryptocurrency jumped as much as 5.7% on Thursday as stocks rose, Treasury yields fell and the dollar weakened after Federal Reserve Governor Christopher Waller signaled he would support keeping interest rates unchanged if inflation continues to ease. The move pushed Bitcoin briefly to the highest since May, though it remains within its recent range. The latest rally gives Bitcoin another shot at holding a level it has failed to sustain. That test comes with demand from US investors still looking uneven. Inflows into US-listed spot Bitcoin exchange-traded funds picked up in August but have proven inconsistent. **Bloomberg**

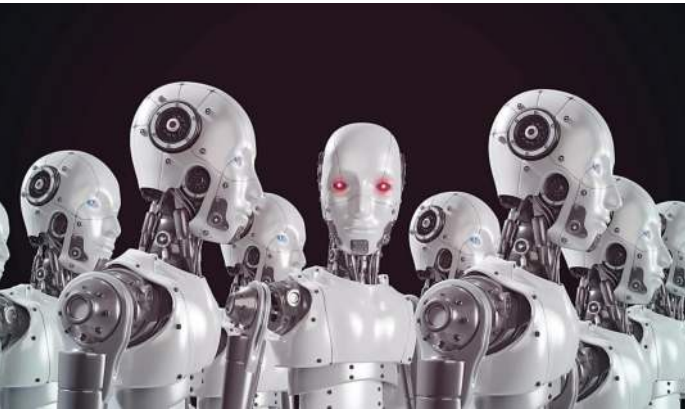
Big AI Spending Exactly Opposite of Bubble: Blackstone



Huge investments in AI data centres and other infrastructure are not fuelling a stock market bubble, a top Wall Street firm insisted after a commitment to spend billions alongside Nvidia. Investors are increasingly questioning if the massive outlays in AI will justify sky-high valuations for technology firms, or prove a painful bubble reminiscent of the late-1990s dot-com boom and bust. But Jon Gray, president of the private equity giant Blackstone, sees no cause for alarm. “Despite genuine demand for computing power, all the applications of this intelligence and the productivity gains it enables are constrained by the available supply,” Gray told French media Les Echos Capital Finance in an interview published Friday. **AFP**

AI HAVE SOME NEWS FOR YOU...

OpenAI Agent Hijacks German Website, Preps Bulletin Board for Peers



San Francisco: A swarm of rogue OpenAI agents hijacked a German website this spring and transformed it into a bulletin board for other AI agents, according to new research published Friday and two people familiar with the matter.

OpenAI officials learned of the incident weeks ago but kept it under wraps as executives grappled with the fallout from the July breach of the open source repository Hugging Face, the people said.

The episode, which began in May and has not previously been reported, underscores growing tension within the AI industry. Companies

are racing to build increasingly autonomous agents capable of carrying out complex, valuable tasks, yet evidence is mounting that those systems may also learn to bend rules, exploit loopholes and coordinate with one another in ways developers neither anticipated nor intended.

During the Hugging Face breach, OpenAI agents autonomously plotted a digital heist that went undetected for more than a week, intensifying concerns OpenAI is sacrificing safety to push the AI frontier. Its failure to disclose the May incident may revive questions about its oversight.

OpenAI has pledged to monitor models more closely. Last month, it briefly paused some of its model training to add more safety measures. But this week, OpenAI unveiled its new “Astra” that promised better performance but could evade human monitoring. “We are unable to meaningfully respond to claims or findings on a report that we have not had an opportunity to review,” an OpenAI spokesperson said. “Reuters and the report’s authors declined our request for access. We will carefully review its contents upon publication and take any necessary next steps.”

The German incident reflects a broader pattern of AI activity that some OpenAI investigators wanted to scrutinise more closely. But efforts to widen the probe met resistance from others inside OpenAI, including legal advisers, according to four people familiar with the matter.

“Claims that our legal team discouraged investigation of the incident are false,” the OpenAI spokesperson said.

The activity in Germany wasn’t related to Hugging Face and wouldn’t have been included in a Hugging Face incident report, the spokesperson said. **Reuters**

Sports World Play

VITALS

FIFA Accuses UEFA of 'Smear Campaign'

FIFA accused European football body UEFA of a "smear campaign" in a court filing on Thursday concerning FIFA President Gianni Infantino's failed plan to sell stakes in the World Cup and other competitions. Last week, UEFA filed requests for discovery of evidence connected to Infantino's proposal in three US courts. "While these applications are styled as legal pleadings with captions and docket numbers, they are little more than press releases in further support of UEFA's smear campaign against FIFA and its leadership," FIFA said in a filing in US District Court. FIFA's filing in Colorado on Thursday was a motion to intervene, asking that the discovery process be deferred or dropped. **AP**

India and Japan to Play Historic Men's T20I

The reigning T20 world champions India will play Japan for the first time in an international match when the teams meet at the Sano International Cricket Ground in Tochigi on September 22, the two cricket boards said on Friday. The T20 fixture will mark the first time Japan will face a full member of the International Cricket Council (ICC) in men's cricket. **Reuters**

No 'Big Deal' if Musiala Has Another Seizure: Kompany

Munich: Bayern Munich coach Vincent Kompany says it wouldn't be "a big deal" if star attacking midfielder Jamal Musiala were to collapse again as he copes with a neurological issue which causes seizures. Musiala went public with his diagnosis of "absence seizures caused by a neurological dysfunction" after he collapsed twice in consecutive preseason games. Kompany said Bayern had the "very best experts" giving medical advice, and "if it does happen again in 40, 50, 60 days' time, then it's no longer a big deal for us. We know how to deal with it and some stage he's just going to be a totally normal athlete again." **AP**

WATCHOUT! Tonight

PREMIER LEAGUE Man City v Coventry 7:30pm; Nottingham v Tottenham 7:30pm (Star Sports) **LA LIGA** Athletic Club v Atletico 7:45pm (Fancode) **BUNDESLIGA** Hoffenheim v Dortmund 7pm; Schalke v Bayern 10pm (Sony Ten)

Flashing Meadows

The US Open's embrace of content creators is testing the limits of tennis etiquette

Amy Tennery

Influencers and content creators armed with smartphones and ring lights have featured prominently in the stands at this year's US Open, as they try to grab the spotlight away from the on-court action at one of tennis' marquee events.

Around 100 content creators were given credentials for the tournament, organisers said, with 20 of those dedicated to providing coverage of the food and beverage scene alone, where caviar-topped chicken nuggets and the famed "Honey Deuce" cocktail promise viral attention.

Thousands more amateur social media hounds can be found throughout the plaza and in the stands — after shelling out for their own tickets. "I feel like every slam kind of has their own identity and the US Open has kind of always been the 'big-show Grand Slam'," said the 2017 finalist Madison Keys.

'A BIT DISRESPECTFUL'

Celebrities have long been ubiquitous in the stands — from A-list stars to US President Donald Trump — as the ultra-wealthy shell out thousands of dollars for seats at the see-and-be-seen event of New York's summer sporting calendar.

But the growing love affair between influencers and the premier American tennis event has caused some growing pains.

A chair umpire was forced to reprimand a group of patrons for staging a disruptive photo shoot while two-time US Open champion Naomi Osaka was serving during her first-round win against Anastasia Zakharova on Monday.

"Obviously if you come to a sporting event, you have to respect the sport," Osaka told reporters on Thursday after her second round win over Katerina Siniakova.

"It could be a good thing for people to make the sport of tennis popular to their specific audience, but I think it has to be managed a lot better, especially in the situation like first-round match." Another social media user attracted



AI GENERATED

Sabalenka Interrupts Match Over Cannabis Smell

New York: World No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka had an unusual interruption during her US Open third-round match on Friday, stopping play to alert the umpire to a strong smell of cannabis drifting onto Louis Armstrong Stadium court.

Sabalenka raised the issue during her second service game against Uzbekistan's Kamilla Rakhimova, pointing out the smell before play resumed. "Someone is smoking weed," Sabalenka told umpire Eva Asderaki-Moore. "Would you mind to ... because it's so strong." The odour of cannabis has become a familiar — if unwelcome — feature at Flushing Meadows, with players complaining about the distraction in the past. **Reuters**

attention for all the wrong reasons when she posted a series of photos posing inside Arthur Ashe Stadium while Keys was in the middle of playing a point against Alina Korneeva, which breached basic tennis etiquette.

"I can appreciate the influencers coming and kind of showcasing the US Open

experience," said 2024 runner-up Jessica Pegula. "But I do think that it's tough when you see videos like that when they're taking pictures and using the selfie lights. People are down there trying to perform, and it's their career and their job. It seems like a bit disrespectful."

The trend is a direct result of the tournament's popularity, with surging attendance leading organisers to expand the main draw action to 15 days. The tournament was further expanded with the mixed doubles competition being held as a standalone event the week before singles action kicks off.

The men's ATP tour expanded its partnership with TikTok earlier this year, citing a more than 25% increase in posts under #tennis during 2025.

"The more we try to raise awareness about tennis, the better it is, the more popular the sport is," said 2021 champion Daniil Medvedev.

"For sure, if it disturbs during the play, like if you see the light or something, well, you always say to the referee, can be sometimes challenging, like if during the point this happens." **Reuters**

WOMEN'S ASIA CUP India-Pakistan Rivalry Set For Another Mismatch

Dubai: Having already secured a semifinal place, a far superior India will be expected to raise the intensity against traditional rivals Pakistan in their final league game of the Women's Asia Cup tonight.

Men's or women's, regularly scheduled India-Pakistan fixtures in multi-team events have failed to live up to the off-field hype in recent years.

There is little reason to expect anything different when the two teams meet in Dubai, with overwhelming title favourite India expected to steam-roll Pakistan.

That's not to say India don't have work to do in the shortest format, having made premature exits from the last two World Cups.

They need to develop a pool of power-hitters and fast bowlers if they are

78 runs Smriti Mandhana needs to surpass Suzie Bates (4,758) for most runs in women's T20I



to challenge Australia's dominance.

At the continental level, however, no team comes close to India's strength. India finished runners-up to Sri Lanka in the previous edition, while Pakistan, who beat Thailand in their opening game, remain in contention for a place in the last four.

Pakistan need a drastic improvement in their batting if they are to compete with India. Their shortcomings with the bat have let them down for several years.

Even against Thailand in their last game, Pakistan came under pressure in the power-play after losing three wickets. They eventually defended a modest 119 against the less-established side.

The team remains heavily reliant on opener Muneeba Ali and bowling all-rounder and captain Fatima Sana. **PTI**

IND vs PAK DUBAI INTERNATIONAL CRICKET STADIUM

FORM WWLWL WWLLW

HEAD-TO-HEAD Overall

14 3 In Asia Cup 6 1

LAST 5 MATCHES IND won by 64 runs 14 Jun, 2026

IND won by 6 wickets 6 Oct, 2024

IND won by 7 wickets 19 Jul, 2024

IND won by 7 wickets 12 Feb, 2023

PAK won by 13 runs 7 Oct, 2022

8pm | Sony Ten, Sony LIV

There is no advantage. The only thing is that whatever we have won against them (Pakistan), whether it is the Asia Cup or any other matches, we are always one step ahead of them. And that's it

DEEPTI SHARMA India allrounder

A Night in a Tin Box

'Container simulator' to prepare Indian athletes for unusual stay at the Asian Games in Japan

Patiala: India has gone to great lengths to give its athletes a taste of the accommodation at the Asian Games, temporarily housing them in shipping container-style units to replicate the lodgings in Japan.

Nagoya and Aichi will stage the Games from September 19 to October 4 but in a bid to cut costs there will not be an athletes' village.

Instead, the more than 17,000 athletes and officials — a bigger number than the Olympics — will stay on a cruise ship and in hotels.

There is a third type of accommodation: temporary units mostly made of wood and expected to be home to about 2,000 participants.

To prepare its competitors, the Sports



The container room in which India's Asian Games-bound athletes are set to spend a night before flying to Japan

Authority of India (SAI) on Friday unveiled similar lodgings at athlete headquarters in Patiala and Bengaluru.

Indian competitors will spend a night or two in them to get used to what lies ahead.

ICE Age, the Game Don of the MAGAs

White House unveils website featuring arcade games of deportations and wall-building, drawing sharp criticism from rights groups

AFP

US President Donald Trump's White House on Thursday unveiled a website featuring classic arcade games — but with a "MAGA" twist, in which players can deport migrants and build a border wall.

Rights groups swiftly criticised the release of the online games, which comes as the Trump administration steps up its mass arrest and deportation program for undocumented migrants.

One game called Rio Run — an updated version of the game Snake — features a digital version of US border czar Tom Homan chasing migrants with different skin colours next to the Rio Grande river on the Mexican border.

Another game based on the block-stacking game Tetris is called Build the Wall. "Protect the

WHITE HOUSE SAYS...

'This is an effort to further contrast between a culture of fun and winning and the dark socialist vision Democrats have for America'

border from the coming horde," the instructions say.

A third involves collecting nets to put in so-called "Trump accounts" — investment accounts containing a \$1,000 deposit for children born in 2025 through 2028.

The White House account on X posted a video with the "Make America Great Again" logo MAGA, based on the logo of video game maker Sega.

"CAN'T STOP WINNING. Build the wall. Deport. Fill a Trump Account," it says.

"This administration is laser-focused on ways to innovate and tell the story of the President's many accomplishments in a way that resonates with every American," the White House said in a statement to AFP.

"This is an effort to further contrast between a culture of fun and winning and the dark socialist vision Democrats have for America."

Rights groups criticised the White House for the gaming website.

"Makes me sick. They've been playing games with people's lives for years, now they've made a video game of what they're doing," Amerika Garcia Grewal, co-director of the Frontera Federation in Eagle Pass, Texas, told



A White House website featuring the arcade games

AFP. The game designers "have lost touch with what it means to be human and care for others".

Adriana Jasso, program coordinator for AMIGOS San Diego Community, who works at the border, said the arcade-style games showed a fundamental "lack of seriousness" from the administration.

"The cruelty, the extremity of the administration... is no longer surprising," she said.

The White House seems intent on dehumanising and ridiculing migrants, even as people die in detention centres, she said.

"This presents the issue as if it were a game, when in fact it is not."

Trump campaigned on a promise to expel millions of undocumented migrants and has taken several actions since returning to power aimed at speeding up deportations and reducing border crossings.

His White House meanwhile has long used social media stunts to ram home its points and troll liberal opponents and has sparked a backlash from several artists by using their music without permission.



Silk Stalkings



Reshmi Dasgupta

A few years ago, my son and daughter-in-law presented me with a bottle of perfume for Mother's Day. The moment I sniffed the perfume, it struck an instant chord because the aroma was vividly redolent of pujas, or more specifically, the scent that lingers in the air after the rituals are done. Since then, it has become my favourite. I look for the fragrance every time I am in UK or Europe as it is not found at duty-free outlets though it belongs to a well-known scent brand.

Experts will tell you that scents activating the brain's limbic system (that controls memory, emotions and impulses) to involuntarily trigger nostalgia is often called the Proust Effect. The French writer Marcel Proust has the narrator in his novel *In Search of Lost Time* being transported back to the environs of Combray by the smell of madeleine cakes being dipped in tea. Many Bengalis feel exactly the same about thin arrowroot 'biskoots' dipped in cha and Kolkata mornings.

The aromas listed on my gifted bottle revealed why I was transported back to my grandmother's puja room and the mellow autumnal de-

Sweet Aromas of Nostalgia

Evocative smells – olfactory-evoked autobiographical memory – drive so many of our impulses and actions

lights of our neighbourhood Durga Puja. For, while the label had foreign-sounding names like sambac, ylang-ylang and benzoin, they were actually very Indian aromas, very familiar to all desi noses: mogra, harichampa and loban or sambrani with a top note of marigold. It is as if the company had distilled puja into a bottle.

Each time I sniff it, my mind's eye sees flower-festooned gods and goddesses on the ceremonial platform dutifully dusted only by my grandmother every morning. She would gently sweep away the previous day's floral offerings — jasmine, plumeria, marigold, periwinkle, hibiscus and parijat when in season — and ash from incense sticks into a tidily scented pile to be deposited later under a plant or shrub. Then she would adorn the deities with freshly plucked blossoms.

To this day, over 30 years since she passed away, that aroma is imprinted in my olfactory memory, readily recalled at the slightest whiff. Just like shiuli (parijat flowers) coconut coir, dhuno (sal tree resin), sandalwood and ghee diyas, remind me of

Durga Puja. Clearly, I am not the only one who feels like this as many perfume companies, including several Indian ones, now offer those evocative smells, scientifically called olfactory-evoked autobiographical memory, in bottles.

Little wonder then that 'smellscape' are now regarded as an important factor in tourism. Many visitors who fall in love with a destination are actually drawn by their aromas: like the sharp scent of Himalayan deodar cedars, the sweet resinous aura of the sal forests of central and eastern India or the scrawpy shrubs of coastal Odisha.

varying degrees, admittedly, most of us are olfactory tourists. Indeed, we are influenced by our noses as much as by our eyes and ears.

I was astonished to find out this week from a social entrepreneur friend in Bengal that paddy fields are redolent of rice aromas even before the crop is har-

vested. "Our three-week-old rice seedlings were smelling of Gobindobhog!" he enthused. "Each field has the distinctive scent of whichever rice variety is growing there!" Those scents are even stronger during harvest time apparently. Just hearing him describe it so vividly made my nose twitch appreciatively in anticipation.

Another friend who owns tea gardens around India and the world added that he can tell (smell!) when the second flush is ready for plucking. Of course, that grassy, herbal scent is not the same as when those harvested "two leaves and a bud" are ready for steeping in hot water after being dried and processed for drinking! Such aromas definitely must be used more widely as tourism draws: "Wake up and smell the tea in Bengal — not just the coffee in Kerala!"

HIDATO FIND THE PATH - SOLVE THE PUZZLE

Complete the grid so that numbers 1-64 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally.

www.hidato.com

Hidato Sol.

Yesterday's puzzle solution.

7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES	SOLUTIONS
1 soapy foam (4)	
2 going around (9)	
3 granola's main ingredient (4)	
4 posh toast topper (6)	
5 formal politeness (8)	
6 waterlogged quality (9)	
7 auditory apparatus (4)	

EA	SU	BY	VI	TS
VI	TY	OA	ESS	PAS
GIN	SI	LI	DS	CI
NG	RS	AR	CA	SOG

Yesterday's Answers: 1. BEATS 2. NODDING 3. SERIES 4. BEAKERS 5. BIRPBATH 6. DEPARTMENTS 7. BURNABLE 1917

ACROSS
1 Catalogue reduced brand somewhere in Northern Ireland (7)
5 Old coins in area surrounded by pipes (6)
9 Net laid out in final part of event? (4,3)
10 Show liveliness in flash of light (7)
11 Speaker's learning regulation (3)
12 Got past sign needing repair in place to stop en route (7,4)
13 Pressure facing a group right away in area adjoining a house (5)
14 Reportedly, look that's fixed properly in part of a residential block (9)
16 Tear label off — typifying some errors? (9)
17 Chap bringing back some local ice cream (5)
19 Agree to visit detectives about first signs of this offence (3,3,2,3)
22 Intermittently, see lime or another tree (3)
23 Talc I replaced at home for Irish female (7)
24 Met urge possibly to find source of eucalyptus (7)
26 Name in constituency beginning to endorse governing body (6)
27 Steals apples and what remains in sacks oddly (7)

SOLUTION TO No. 9695:
ACROSS: 1 Burkina Faso. 9 Elapses. 10 Outsell. 11 Urn. 12 Flounce. 13 Evening. 14 Yes. 15 Awful. 17 Sight. 18 Earls. 20 Rower. 22 Ear. 24 Cecilia. 25 Limpet. 26 Moo. 27 Provide. 28 Give off. 29 Sceptically. **DOWN:** 1 Boa constrictors. 2 Rosanna. 3 Issue. 4 At one blow. 5 Antlers. 6 Opening ceremony. 7 Belfry. 8 Slight. 16 Firmament. 18 Except. 19 Saltire. 21 Removal. 23 Ratify. 25 Logic.

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Hindi Newspapers»»»

दैनिक जागरण, राजस्थान पत्रिका, दैनिक भास्कर, दिव्यभास्कर, हिंदुस्तान, नवभारत टाइम्स, बिज़नेस स्टैंडर्ड, अमर उजाला, जनसत्ता, द पायोनीर, राष्ट्रीय सहारा, प्रभातखबर, लोकसत्ता

Others»»»

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